

INBRIEF



Bengal CM drives road roller over cough syrup bottles

West Bengal Chief Minister Suven- du Adhikari on Wednesday drove a road roller over two lakh bottles of codeine-based cough syrup in Balurghat, saying the State is committed to fight against drugs abuse. He was accompanied by Balurghat MP Sukanta Majumdar, Health Minister Sharadwat Mukherjee at the event in Dakshin Dinajpur district. The banned cough syrup bottles were lined up outside the Superintendent of Police’s office. The CM drove the roller over the bottles as a message against drug abuse and drug peddling in the State and a warning to smugglers.

LJP (RV) demands enhanced security for Chirag after threat

The Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) [LJP (RV)] on Wednesday sought enhanced security for party president Chirag Paswan after he allegedly received a death threat. A delegation of LJP(RV) leaders met Bihar DGP Vinay Kumar and raised concerns over the threat messages, which, according to Mr. Paswan’s office, claimed that he would be “killed by terrorists”. The Union Minister, a Z-category protectee, received the messages on Tuesday, his office said. “I, along with other party legislators met the DGP. We conveyed our concern over the threat. The DGP assured us the matter is being investigated,” party’s State chief Surender Vivek said.

Rahul’s Indore event postponed after stadium nod denied: Cong.

Press Trust of India
INDORE

The Congress on Wednesday said party leader Rahul Gandhi’s ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ event in Indore, earlier planned to be held on September 12, has been postponed to September 19 due to the State government’s denial of permission to use a city-based stadium as the programme venue.

State Congress president Jitu Patwari made the announcement during a meeting held to take stock of the preparations for the event.

He said that the State government denied permission to hold ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium here and the party will now find a new venue for the event and make preparations accordingly.

Earlier, Mr. Patwari wrote a letter to Chief Minister Mohan Yadav requesting him to make the



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addressing a gathering during a ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ programme in Pune. FILE PHOTO

stadium available for the September 12 event.

In the letter, he said Mr. Gandhi’s programme is not a typical political event, but a public dialogue focused on important issues such as the country’s future, the dreams of youth, the right to education, and the security of the education system.

Nehru Stadium falls under the jurisdiction of the Indore Municipal Corporation.

Mayor Pushyamitra Bhargava said that the Madhya Pradesh High

Court has clearly stated that only sports activities or State-level government programmes can be permitted at the stadium.

Mobilising students

The Congress is trying to mobilise 50,000 students from Indore and surrounding areas for the programme.

‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ is a student-dialogue campaign launched by the Congress, under which programmes are being organised in various cities across the country.

Inside Delhi prisons: a web of gangs, collusion and proposed transfers

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

On April 6 this year, a clash among inmates inside Mandoli jail left a 22-year-old murder accused seriously injured. Three months later, the Delhi government’s Anti-Corruption Branch arrested 11 people, including seven prison officials, in an alleged extortion and bribery racket involving prisons in Tihar, Rohini and Mandoli.

The incidents have again put the functioning of Delhi’s prisons under scrutiny amid concerns over gang rivalries, contraband, staff collusion and communication between inmates and associates outside. The concern is particularly significant given the presence of several high-profile gangsters and or-



Gangsters such as Neeraj Bawana (left) have been lodged in Tihar jail since 2015; Lawrence Bishnoi was lodged in Tihar and Mandoli prisons while facing trial between 2021 and 2023. FILE PHOTOS



ganised criminals across the city’s three major prison complexes. Gangsters such as Neeraj Bawana and Chhota Rajan have been lodged in Tihar jail since 2015, while Hashim Baba has been there since 2019 and is allegedly operating his syndicate from behind bars. Anmol Bishnoi has also been in high-security custody in Tihar jail since November 2025.

Against this backdrop,

the Delhi government is considering transferring “hardened and notorious” prisoners, including undertrial gangsters, organised criminals and other high-risk inmates, to prisons in other States under the Transfer of Prisoners (Punjab Amendment) Act, 2025. The proposed move would allow undertrials to be transferred to prisons outside the State besides convicted prisoners. The

history of Lawrence Bishnoi, who was lodged in Tihar and Mandoli prisons while facing trial before being shifted to Sabarmati Central Jail in Gujarat, also highlights the relevance of allowing undertrials to be transferred between States.

Prison promises

Former inmates who spent five to 20 years in Delhi prisons told *The Hindu* that they were approached with offers of money, help in court cases and other favours. “During my first interim bail, after four and a half years in prison, I was offered ₹10 lakh to carry out a ‘task’ and promised help with my case,” said a former inmate lodged in a murder case.

Sunil Kumar Gupta, a former legal adviser, superintendent and spokesper-

son of Central Jail in Tihar, said gang members identify ‘useful’ inmates and exploit vulnerabilities such as financial distress, pending cases and drug dependence. “Once trust is established, recruits may be used to move contraband, extort money or carry out crimes after release or while on bail,” he said.

Mr. Gupta said transferring gang leaders could disrupt such networks, but warned that influential prisoners could try to manipulate the process.

‘Not all gaps closed’

Technology, meanwhile, has not closed all the gaps. A prison official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said inmates continued to find ways around mobile phone jammers by exploiting weak coverage, using newer networks or having

equipment tampered with, sometimes with staff support. Contraband can enter through visitors, parcels and mail, over prison walls or during court movements, the official said. “Prisons need better screening equipment, including body scanners and X-ray systems,” he added.

Mr. Gupta said staff shortages, inadequate training and the perception of jail duty as a “punishment posting” have made prisons vulnerable to collusion.

While the proposed transfers may help reduce some links between gangs inside and outside prisons, their effectiveness would also depend on addressing issues such as staff shortages, corruption and gaps in supervision, which can allow such networks to persist or adapt.

Allahabad HC quashes law student’s NSA detention, calls case ‘concocted story’

Akriti Chaudhary was arrested during the workers’ protest in Noida in April; the court flagged discrepancies in the arrest notice and directed Noida administration to pay ₹5 lakh compensation

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday quashed the detention of Delhi University law student Akriti Chaudhary under the National Security Act (NSA). The 25-year-old has spent nearly five months in custody over the workers’ protest in Noida in April this year.

A Bench of Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Achal Sachdev allowed Ms. Chaudhary’s *habeas corpus* plea and ordered her immediate release, unless she was required in another case. The court flagged discrepancies in the arrest notice and called the State’s version a “concocted story”.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, advocate Charlie Prakash, who represented Ms. Chaudhary along with senior advocate Colin Gonsalves, confirmed that the court has quashed the detention.



There is no factual basis for my detention, and the process leading to the preventive detention was procedurally and substantively flawed

AKRITI CHAUDHARY in her habeas corpus petition

“The court found major inconsistencies in the State’s account of her arrest and detention. The court has also asked the DM Noida to pay her compensation of ₹5 lakh,” he added.

Ms. Chaudhary was among several activists arrested in cases related to the protest held between April 10 and 18, during which industrial and contractual workers demanded salary hikes and parity with wages paid in neighbouring Haryana.

On April 13, the protest had turned violent and roads were blocked.

The Uttar Pradesh Police invoked the NSA

against Ms. Chaudhary a month later and alleged that she had instigated protesters to engage in stone-pelting and arson. During a press conference, the police claimed to have “strong electronic and videographic evidence” against her.

In her petition, Ms. Chaudhary argued that she was already in custody before the violence began on April 13. She said that there was no factual basis for her detention, and the process leading to her preventive detention was procedurally and substantively flawed.

The State had submitted in the court that Ms.

Chaudhary was arrested at 10.56 a.m. on April 12 and was issued a warning notice under Section 130 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita. Justice Sreedharan questioned why no showcause notice was issued before the warning.

The State accepted that no notice was served under Section 126. The court then called for the police’s general diary, which showed that Ms. Chaudhary was arrested before the notice was prepared. The court asked whether she had been produced before a magistrate before the arrest and asked for evidence of incitement.

The State told the court that protesters gathered at the site on April 11, but the court pointed out that, according to police records, no violence took place that day. The State also failed to submit the video footage showing Ms. Chaudhary provoked protesters. to throw stones or set vehicles on fire.

‘Relieved, but fight will go on till all workers come out’

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Akriti Chaudhary, the 25-year-old Delhi University student, expressed relief over the Allahabad High Court order quashing the National Security Act (NSA) against her. However, her struggle will continue until the release of all those jailed following the workers’ protest in April this year, she added.

“The NSA charge being quashed is a great relief but the fight will not end until the release of all workers and activists,” she told *The Hindu* at the prison in Greater Noida.

Ms. Chaudhary then turned to Satyam Verma, the other individual against whom the police had invoked the stringent law on May 13, and said, “Hopefully he is also freed of all the charges.”

Tears were clearly visible on her face behind an iron mesh barrier, where she stood with other activists waiting to meet friends and family.

Her father, Arun Chaudhary, said, “My daughter is the Bhagat Singh of today. She always had full support from us. We never felt she had done anything

wrong. I have full faith in the justice system.”

“A cheerful and sensitive person such as Akriti can never pose any kind of threat to national security. But she was declared a threat to the nation just for trying to create a better society. Even the NSA could not break her courage,” said Naureen, a history graduate and friend.

Ms. Chaudhary hails from Durgapur in West Bengal and is in her first year of LLB at DU’s Law Faculty.

Speaking about her experience in prison, Ms. Chaudhary said she took the initiative to cook and clean, and also taught the children of women inmates. Along with Manisha Chauhan and Srishiti, who were also taken into custody by the Uttar Pradesh police in protest-related cases, she says she restarted a defunct library and encouraged others to read. “We have been working because there is nothing wrong with maintaining and taking care of the place we live in,” said the DU student. The three also attended various vocational classes in the prison, including tailoring and cosmetics, she said.

Job aspirants protest outside U.P. Deputy CM’s residence over delay in recruitment

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Hundreds of candidates seeking recruitment to 3,284 Junior Assistant posts staged a protest outside the official residence of Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak on Wednesday demanding completion of the recruitment and appointment process by the Uttar Pradesh Subordinate Services Selection Commission (UPSSSC).

The job aspirants held placards and accused the State government of neglecting their grievances and delaying the process.

Following the protest, Mr. Pathak met the aspirants and said he has instructed officials to resolve the issue immediately. “I met the candidates and spoke to the UPSSSC Chairman. I have instructed that their issues be resolved immediately. Our government stands firmly with students and the youth. We are working on meeting



Deputy CM Brajesh Pathak (right) meeting aspirants after they staged a protest outside his residence on Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

their demands,” he said.

The Deputy Chief Minister added that all students desire a speedy resolution. “I have just directed the UPSSSC Chairman to ensure that the typing examination is held promptly in accordance with the students’ demands,” he said.

‘False assurances’

The aspirants said they have been waiting for the typing test for a long time.

“We met the Deputy Chief Minister regarding

be considered and that they are deliberating on it.

“We want them to issue an official notice confirming that the typing test for the 3,284 vacant posts will take place in October. It is already significantly delayed,” Mr. Mishra said.

Meanwhile, the Opposition Congress extended support to the aspirants’ demands and alleged that the Bharatiya Janata Party government in the State has “failed” in providing employment to the youth.

“The government made tall promises about employment generation, but it has completely failed. Aspirants were forced to reach the Deputy CM’s residence for regular and time-bound recruitment. The recruitment calendar is not being followed. Our leader Rahul Gandhiji was in Prayagraj holding a dialogue with the youth. We will support them in every way possible,” Congress national secretary Shahna-waz Alam said.

Helicopter ‘misuse’ plea against Patnaik dismissed

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

A court here on Wednesday dismissed a criminal revision petition against former Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik and ex-IAS officer V.K. Pandian in an alleged expenditure of around ₹500 crore from the State exchequer by undertaking 300 helicopter tours.

Khurda District Sessions Judge Biranchi Narayan Mohanty said the petitioner failed to substantiate any offence, did not follow the mandatory procedure under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, and lacked locus standi to file the complaint.

The court also found no illegality in the March 25 order of the Sub-Divisional Judicial Magistrate, Bhubaneswar, which dismissed the original complaint. The revision petition was rejected as “devoid of merit,” the court order said.

Maharashtra poll rolls: Cong. seeks more time for claims, objections

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

With 2.06 crore names in Maharashtra not figuring in the draft electoral roll following a special intensive revision (SIR), the State Congress on Wednesday demanded that sufficient time be given for filing claims and objections.

It also demanded that the hearing process be made more convenient, and the entire exercise be conducted in a transparent manner.

2.06 cr. names deleted

More than 2.06 crore names, accounting for 21.14% of the State’s previous voter base, have not

figured in the draft electoral roll. The draft roll currently has more than 7.71 crore names (78.86% of the previous electorate), comprising 3.95 crore men, 3.75 crore women, and 3,087 third-genders, according to State election authorities.

The Congress sought extension of the deadline for claims and objections until November 30.

The current period from August 31 to September 30 is insufficient. Moreover, the Ganesh festival falls during this period, when many citizens travel to their native places. Therefore, the deadline for filing claims and objections should be extended until November 30, 2026, it said.



Formulate rules for fishing vessel transit to EEZ, SC directs T.N.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Seeking cooperative federalism between the Centre and the State to regulate purse seine fishing, the Supreme Court on Wednesday directed Tamil Nadu to frame rules to create a “specified channel” or official navigation corridor under the Marine Fishing Regulation Rules, 2020 for transit of vessels from its territorial waters to Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZ) for fishing using such nets.

Tamil Nadu had banned purse seine fishing within its territorial waters in 2000.

Wednesday’s direction by a Division Bench headed by Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe was part of a judgment that considered applications concerning the rights of fishermen using purse seine nets to access the EEZ beyond the territorial waters of Tamil Nadu.

The State had expressed concern that fishermen could use such nets within its territorial waters under the guise of fishing in the EEZ. It would be difficult for the State to regulate it.

On the other hand, the fishing community had argued that Tamil Nadu was invoking the 2020 Rules, notified to enforce the State’s ban, to prevent them from even carrying these purse seine nets to the EEZ for fishing beyond 12 nautical miles, which is outside the State’s remit.

But the court said fishing within and outside the territorial waters of the



State was covered by Tamil Nadu Marine Fishing Regulation Rules, 2020, and the Central law of Sustainable Harnessing of Fisheries in the Exclusive Economic Zone Rules (EEZ Rules), 2025. The 2020 Rules regulate fishing within Tamil Nadu’s territorial waters and the use of gear.

The EEZ Rules contemplate the issuance of ‘access pass’ to fishing vessels permitted in the EEZ. Upholding both the 2020 and 2025 Rules, the court directed that the “rights and liabilities of the parties will now be governed as per the relevant laws, EEZ Rules, 2025 and the Tamil Nadu Marine Fishing Regulation Rules, 2020”.

“We now have the entire legal regime through which purse seine fishing can be regulated in the EEZ, while addressing the concerns of the State... There is no conflict between the EEZ Rules of the Union and the Marine Fishery Regulation Rules, 2020 of the State of Tamil Nadu,” the court observed.

Agniveer involvement ruled out in military weapon theft

Military Intelligence has joined the investigation into the missing service weapons from 20 Madras Regiment premises in Secunderabad; probe being conducted from an undisclosed location

Naveen Kumar
HYDERABAD

The Malkajigiri Police have reportedly ruled out the involvement of Agniveers in the theft of service weapons and ammunition from the 20 Madras Regiment premises in Bollaram, Secunderabad Cantonment, even as the investigation continues under heightened secrecy inside the defence area.

Military Intelligence has also joined the investigation into the theft, with the probe being conducted from within the defence area at an undisclosed location to maintain confidentiality.



Missing gear: The stolen service weapons include four AK-203 assault rifles and six 9mm pistols. IMAGE FOR REPRESENTATION

Sources said even staff at the Bollaram Police Station were not aware of the status of the investigation or the details of the probe.

The restrictions on shar-

ing information come amid heightened security following the theft of four AK-203 assault rifles, an INSAS IBI rifle, six 9 mm Auto 1A pistols and a civilian 6.35-bore pistol from the

Army premises. A passive night-vision binocular and more than 1,800 rounds of ammunition were also reported missing.

The discrepancy was detected around 7.50 a.m. on Monday when the Kote and Battalion Magazine was opened and the locks were found broken. The weapons and ammunition were last physically accounted for around 6 p.m. on August 30.

The Army subsequently reverified its weapon and ammunition holdings and accounting records, searched authorised storage areas and adjoining premises and checked issue and receipt registers.

Sunni leader’s observations on women unsuitable for modern Keralam, says CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Rejecting Sunni leader Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar’s recent controversial opinions against the participation of women in public platforms, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said his comments are unsuitable for modern and progressive Keralam.

Addressing a press conference in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday

after the Cabinet meeting, Mr. Satheesan said that neither the Congress nor the State government can agree with such a stand that belongs to the 19th century.

“Even Islamic history and its scriptures say that women have a place in public spaces. Such comments are a result of misinterpretation of Islam. Khadija, the first wife of the Prophet, was a businesswoman, while Aysha, another wife, had led an



V.D. Satheesan

army in a war. Women’s voices were respected in the court of Khalifa Umar,” Mr. Satheesan said.

Meanwhile, the Kerala Muslim Jamaat con-

demned Mr. Satheesan’s remarks that Mr. Aboobacker Musliar had misinterpreted Islam. It demanded that the Chief Minister withdraw the statement and apologise to the Muslim community.

The Muslim Jamaat said Mr. Satheesan had misunderstood Islamic history and commented on them without properly considering their context. Such remarks, it said, were unbecoming of the office of the Chief Minister.

Katchatheevu row resurfaces in Tamil Nadu Assembly

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The issue of India handing over Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka in 1974 rocked the Assembly on Wednesday, with Ministers from the ruling TVK accusing the then DMK government led by M. Karunanidhi of “failing to stop” the Centre from handing over the islet to the neighbouring country.

During the discussion on the demands for grants for the Fisheries and Fishermen Welfare Department, Ramanathapuram MLA Katharbatcha Muthuramalingam of the DMK highlighted the ordeals faced by fishermen from Tamil Nadu at the hands of the Sri Lankan Navy mid-sea, particularly after the enactment of a law in Sri Lanka that provided for the confiscation of fishing vessels in addition to the arrest of fishermen.

Minister for Water Resources N. Anand intervened and said it was the DMK that gave away Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka. DMK members objected to his remark.

DMK whip E.V. Velu said Katchatheevu was handed over to Sri Lanka based on a decision taken by then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. The then Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, Karunanidhi, had opposed the move, he said, adding that the issue had been raised several times, and resolutions had been passed in the Assembly seeking the retrieval of Katchatheevu from Sri Lanka.



Minister N. Anand accused the then DMK government of failing to prevent the handover of the islet to Sri Lanka in 1974.

Minister for Energy Resources and Law C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar questioned what the Tamil Nadu government at the time had done even if the Union government had decided to hand over Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka.

He referred to a similar attempt by the Union government in the 1950s to transfer Berubari Union to what was then East Pakistan.

He said then West Bengal Chief Minister B.C. Roy had approached the Supreme Court and won a case against the transfer of the Indian territory in 1960. When the Centre decided to hand over Katchatheevu to Sri Lanka in the 1970s, Foreign Secretary Kewal Singh had discussed the matter with Karunanidhi twice, he said. “*Kalaig-nar* [Karunanidhi] himself told mediapersons about Kewal Singh discussing the matter with him. Only with the consent of *Kalaig-nar* was Katchatheevu given to Sri Lanka, he said.

INBRIEF



Aero India 2027 to be held in Bengaluru from February 8

Aero India, Asia’s largest air show and among the world’s premier aerospace and defence exhibitions, will return for its 16th edition at Air Force Station, Yelahanka, in Bengaluru from February 8 to 12, 2027. Exhibitor registrations are scheduled to begin on September 3, 2026. A major attraction of the event will be aerial displays by the Indian Air Force and participating international flying teams. Aero India 2027 is being organised by the Department of Defence Production under the Ministry of Defence.

Keralam seeks technical study of Mullaperiyar Dam

Keralam has demanded a rigorous, long-term technical evaluation of the Mullaperiyar Dam before the five-member comprehensive safety panel. The State submitted an eight-page written document detailing its safety concerns. Both Keralam and Tamil Nadu presented their arguments during the meeting, officials said. The demand comes as the panel began inspection of the main dam, baby dam, earthen dam, and spillway on Tuesday. The panel’s chairman, former NHPG CMD Balraj Joshi, said that the committee will submit its report in two weeks.

Karnataka all for NITI Aayog’s ‘second Bengaluru’ proposal

The NITI Aayog has suggested that the Karnataka consider building a “second Bengaluru” in the State to reduce the pressure on the capital. The suggestion came from NITI Aayog Vice-Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri during a meeting with Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar in Bengaluru on Wednesday. “I am proud of Karnataka’s development. To reduce pressure on Bengaluru, there is a need to seriously consider building a second Bengaluru in Karnataka,” said Mr. Lahiri. The Chief Minister said a proper plan would be prepared as per NITI Aayog’s expectations.

Godavari reaches north A.P. through Polavaram canal

Hareesh.P
PAYAKARAOPET

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Wednesday laid out a road map for augmenting water supply to the Uttaraandhra region through various projects and interlinking of rivers.

Releasing the Godavari water to the north Andhra region through the Polavaram Left Main Canal at PL Puram village in Anakapalli district on Wednesday, he said: “I had promised to bring the Godavari water to Uttaraandhra and fulfilled it,” he said. He thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi for the merger of seven mandals in Telangana with Andhra Pradesh, without which Polavaram project would have remained a dream.

The project, executed at a cost of ₹4,192 crore, will



N. Chandrababu Naidu joins the prayers before opening the gates of Polavaram Left Main Canal in Anakapalli on Wednesday.

ensure water for irrigating four lakh acres, drinking water to 9.23 lakh people, and will meet the industrial needs of East Godavari, Kakinada, Konaseema, Anakapalli, and Visakhapatnam districts. He said 72% of Polavaram project works had been completed by 2019, but the previous government had neglected the project.

“With the blessings of Annavaram Satyanarayana

Swamy, we have brought the Godavari river water to Anakapalli. By next year, water will reach near Simhadri Appanna (Simhachalam in Visakhapatnam) and Suryanarayana Swamy at Arasavalli in future, realising the goal of interlinking of the Godavari with the Vamsadhara river. We will offer ‘Jala Harathi’ to every acre of land by interlinking the Godavari with the Krishna,” he said.

BJP urges Karnataka CM to sack Ministers over graft allegation

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A recent letter to Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar by Congress MLA Ashok Kumar Rai, accusing two engineers of Karnataka Rural Infrastructure Development Limited (KRIDL) of collecting extra charges from contractors stating that it has to be given to the Dakshina Kannada district in-charge Minister and the department Minister, has now taken a serious turn with the BJP urging the Chief Minister to sack these two Ministers.

Addressing a press conference in Bengaluru on Wednesday, Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly R. Ashoka urged the government to immediately dismiss the two Ministers who are allegedly taking

bribes and also hand over the investigation to CBI.

In the letter, Mr. Rai has stated that an extra 7% of money is being collected from contractors in KRIDL, allegedly to be given to these Ministers and that contractors who questioned it are being threatened.

‘Commission raj’

Mr. Ashok alleged that after the Congress came to power, officials were acting in an unruly manner and the government was running a “commission raj.”

“If ₹100 is released, only ₹30 worth of work is done. The remaining 70% goes as commission. When we made the allegation, they asked for documents. Now a Congress MLA himself has spoken about the commission,” he said.

Siddaramaiah backs drive to nurture OBC leadership

Nagesh Prabhu
BENGALURU

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah is backing the formation of Shudra Seva Sanghas in universities and colleges across the State to draw young people from Other Backward Classes (OBCs) into public life and help develop a new generation of political leaders. The initiative assumes significance against the backdrop of the growing visibility of Gen Z-led protests in the country.

Mr. Siddaramaiah recently inaugurated a Shudra Seva Sangha in Bengaluru, and attended the sangha meetings with the objective of involving students belonging to OBCs in social and political activities and nurturing leadership qualities among them.

Pichavaram mangroves valued at ₹2,485 crore: study

K.C. Deepika
BENGALURU

How valuable are mangroves? A recent study of the Pichavaram mangrove ecosystem in Tamil Nadu estimated its total economic value (TEV) at ₹2,485.38 crore, with a per-hectare value of ₹1.83 crore, reflecting the ecological, economic, and social benefits it provides.

The Pichavaram Mangrove Forest is deemed one of the most ecologically significant coastal wetland ecosystems in India and plays a vital role in supporting biodiversity conservation, fisheries productivity, coastal protection, climate regulation,

blue carbon sequestration, and livelihood security for coastal communities.

“Mangrove ecosystems provide a wide range of provisioning, regulating, supporting, and cultural ecosystem services that contribute significantly to ecological sustainability and human well-being. Despite their importance, many ecosystem services remain undervalued in conventional development planning because several ecological benefits are non-market in nature and are not reflected in market transactions,” says the study. “Economic valuation and blue carbon assessment of ecosystem services (ESV) in the Pichavaram



Green gold: Pichavaram Mangrove Forest is a highly significant coastal wetland ecosystem in India. FILE PHOTO

Mangrove Forest”.

The study, by M. Balasubramanian, Associate Professor, Centre for Ecological Economics and Natural Resources, Institute for Social and Economic Change, Bengaluru, was funded by

the Deputy Conservator of Forests, Forest Genetics Division, Coimbatore. It was based on primary and secondary data; primary information was collected from 302 households across five mangrove-de-

pendent villages: MGR Thittu, Kalaig-nar Nagar, Chinnavaikal, Patriadi, and Mudasalodai.

Carbon sink

“The blue carbon assessment highlights the critical role of the Pichavaram mangroves as a significant natural carbon sink and a valuable climate regulation asset,” says the study.

The analysis further revealed that mangrove sediments constitute an even more substantial carbon reservoir. The average soil organic carbon stock of 251.14 tonnes of carbon per hectare was estimated to generate an economic value of ₹90.24 lakh per hectare, resulting in a total soil

organic carbon value of ₹1,224.63 crore. When vegetation and soil carbon pools are combined, the total blue carbon asset value of the Pichavaram Mangrove Ecosystem is estimated at ₹1,612.40 crore.

The study recommends the integration of ecosystem service valuation into coastal development planning and environmental decision-making, the recognition of mangroves as key nature-based solutions for climate adaptation and disaster risk reduction, and the development of blue carbon financing mechanisms, carbon credit programmes, and Payment for Ecosystem Services schemes.

Air Force veteran appointed first Ram Temple Trust CEO

Cong. cites Garg's analysis to question GDP growth figures

Jharkhand BJP demands investigation by the CBI into 'scam' in examinations

Former AIMIM leader joins Congress ahead of 2027 U.P. election

Mr. Rai said Mr. Waqar's induction would strengthen the party in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the 2027 Assembly election. A key AIMIM voice in Uttar Pradesh and considered close to Mr. Owaisi, Mr. Waqar's exit comes as the AIMIM seeks to expand its political footprint in the State.

Moving towards a universal vaccine against pneumonia and meningitis

Scientists are looking for a universal pneumococcal vaccine that can target all the hundred or so forms of *Streptococcus pneumonia* bacteria, and prevent some undesirable outcomes created by existing vaccines that keep the threat of pneumococcal diseases alive in the human population

S. Swaminathan

There is a bacterium called *Streptococcus pneumoniae*. It comes in at least a hundred different forms, or serotypes, and lives in the tissue lining our nose and throat. *S. pneumoniae* is normally harmless. But when your body's immune system becomes weaker, for example when you have a viral fever, these bacteria may invade your lungs and cause pneumonia, your brain and spinal cord to cause meningitis, and your bloodstream to cause sepsis.

These diseases are called pneumococcal diseases, and fortunately, they can be prevented by vaccines. Each of these vaccines contains a unique sugary substance called a capsular polysaccharide, aimed at each serotype of *S. pneumoniae*. That is, they offer protection specific to each serotype.

And the current crop of pneumococcal vaccines protect against only a subset of the 100-odd serotypes. To increase coverage, scientists need to include additional serotype-specific capsular polysaccharides in the vaccine. And covering all the serotypes in a single shot would be extremely challenging, not to mention extremely expensive as well.

Sugary shot

Recently, a team of British scientists reported an important first step in this direction. They did two things: first, they switched the polysaccharide with proteins and, second, they adopted an approach called reverse vaccinology.

Basically, two kinds of pneumococcal vaccines are available today. One is a mix of purified capsular polysaccharides from multiple serotypes. Pneumovax 23 is an example. It does not work well in infants and offers short-lived protection.

To help boost the effects as well as the durability of the immune response, scientists have linked the polysaccharides to a carrier protein. Such vaccines are known as pneumococcal conjugate vaccines (PCVs). Typical examples include PCV10 and PCV14; the numerals denote the number of serotypes included.

When these vaccines target and eliminate some serotypes of *S. pneumoniae*, it also opens the door for other serotypes to mount an infection. These non-vaccine serotypes also face less biological competition for space and resources, so they multiply and eventually replace the vaccine-targeted serotypes, rendering the vaccines obsolete.

Second, many non-vaccine serotypes either possess antibiotic resistance genes or can acquire them from their resistant counterparts. This leads to the rise of both vaccine- and antibiotic-resistant serotypes.

Thus, scientists are looking for a universal pneumococcal vaccine that can target all serotypes and prevent these outcomes, which keep the threat of pneumonia, meningitis, and other pneumococcal diseases alive in the population.



The agar plate with red blood cells on the left shows a positive Staphylococcus infection and on the right shows a positive Streptococcus infection. NCI/UNSPASH

Reverse vaccinology starts from the germ's genome to identify proteins that can be included in vaccines. Scientists demonstrated an example of this in the recent COVID-19 pandemic: once the virus's genome was sequenced in early 2020, scientists around the world could analyse it and zero in on the spike-protein gene to make COVID-19 vaccines. The approach completely bypassed the need to culture the germs in large bioreactors and purify molecular components from them to make the vaccine.

The *S. pneumoniae* genome encodes more than 2,000 genes. Of them, around 1,300 are common across serotypes. The genomic data of more than 20,000 *S. pneumoniae* isolates across nearly a hundred serotypes are also available in the public domain.

The scientists deployed extensive computational analysis using an arsenal of bioinformatic tools to analyse these sequences.

They reasoned that the best candidate genes for creating their universal vaccine would need to encode for proteins with three attributes: (i) it must be located on the surface so that the immune system can easily access it; (ii) it must have low or no similarity to human proteins, so that the immune system does not attack the body's tissue, and (iii) it must be capable of eliciting a robust and durable anti-pneumococcal immunity.

The team shortlisted some candidates and further whittled the list down based on their predicted shapes and stability. From this, the team picked three

candidate genes. They were: zinc metalloprotease B (Z), pneumococcal adherence virulence factor A (P), and a protein which the scientists designated YfhO-like (Y) due to its similarity to another bacterial protein.

The team produced proteins Z, P, and Y in the laboratory and made an experimental vaccine by mixing them together. They also added two non-protein immune response boosters: a small piece of synthetic DNA called CpG and a sugary polymer called chitosan. They named this formulation ZPY-CpG-Ch.

Potent antibodies

To test whether the vaccine could elicit protective anti-pneumococcal antibodies, the scientists vaccinated laboratory mice. After some time, they exposed the mice to a lethal dose of *S. pneumoniae* serotype 1, which is known to be hypervirulent. Compared to unvaccinated mice, all of which succumbed to the lethal dose, vaccinated mice showed 80-100% survival.

Importantly, the scientists found that the level of protection offered by ZPY-CpG-Ch was comparable to that of PCV13.

The team also found that antibodies from the mice vaccinated with ZPY-CpG-Ch could help kill *S. pneumoniae* bacteria in a test tube. When injected into unvaccinated mice, the antibodies could also protect them against a lethal dose of serotype 1.

Third, ZPY-CpG-Ch fully protected

vaccinated mice exposed to lethal doses of two non-vaccine serotypes, 11A and 33F. It also offered 50% protection against a third non-vaccine serotype, called serotype 8.

In all mouse experiments, measures of the vaccine's protective effect based on the bacterial load in lungs and blood mirrored the rodents' survival rates. However, the ZPY-CpG-Ch vaccine did not reduce the load of pneumococcal bacteria in the upper respiratory passages of vaccinated mice. That is, despite being protected, vaccinated mice have the ability to still spread the infection to uninfected mice.

Worthy goal

Finally, the team also reported that vaccinating mice with ZPY-CpG-Ch stimulated a subset of immune cells that are implicated in pneumococcal immunity.

The results from this work are too preliminary for ZPY-CpG-Ch to be a universal pneumococcal vaccine. It has also been tested against a very small subset of serotypes, four to be precise. Vaccine data from laboratory mice also may not truly reflect the human situation.

Nevertheless, this work represents a baby step towards the worthy goal of developing a universal pneumococcal vaccine.

(S. Swaminathan is a retired professor of biology at BITS-Pilani, Hyderabad, and a former scientist at ICGEB, New Delhi. ssn225@gmail.com)



Scientist Akiko Takii collects samples from a young Asiatic black bear before releasing it back into the wild in Nagano, Japan, in July 2026. AFP

An alternative emerges to check Japan's bear troubles

Agence France-Presse

As a sensor sounded, scientist Akiko Takii hurried to a bear trap deep in the forests of Nagano in Japan, where rising attacks have brought fear and resulted in the culling of thousands of the animals. "It is a small bear, I think, about a year and a half old," Ms. Takii said as she peered at the 15-kilogramme Asiatic black bear thrashing in the cage. "It must have just parted from mum." Its mother was not around, and Ms. Takii took blood and fur samples after her co-researcher tranquilised the young female. The animal was too small to be tagged with a GPS tracker, so she was released.

The process of trapping, tagging, and releasing the animals is part of a pioneering management plan launched in 1995, as authorities realised the bear population was shrinking in the mountainous region in the centre of Japan's Honshu island. And it is becoming part of a model of coexistence in the region that some experts believe is an alternative to the dominant practice of culling the animals in an effort to prevent attacks. "By not killing too many of them, more bears survive to live out their expected lifespan. In that sense, a healthy bear population is being formed," Ms. Takii said of the process, which is paired with other methods intended to keep bears away from humans and monitor their movement.

Even before a cull guidance in Japan was expanded in April, large numbers of bears were being killed; however, several communities are embracing co-existence to prevent attacks

Another group in the area used specially trained Karelian Bear Dogs to scare bears away, and more than 3,000 kilometres of fencing was installed near farms, towns, and along rivers to prevent encounters. Bears who slip through are tranquilised, tagged, and set free far away. The programme has been credited with prompting both a recovery in bear numbers – although the animals are hard to count – and fewer encounters with humans.

There is little sympathy across much of Japan for healthy bear populations. Bears have killed six people nationwide since April 1, after a record 13 fatal attacks last fiscal year, according to the Environment Ministry. Sightings last year doubled the previous record and bears are increasingly entering the outskirts of towns and cities.

The causes are complex and, including variations in the availability of food like acorns, are potentially linked to climate change. The emptying out of rural areas due to depopulation and urbanisation is also leaving forests, farmland, and buffer zones less managed, said Shuichi Kitoh, a Tokyo University professor emeritus of environmental ethics. The government's response has focused largely on culling bears, expanding the process beyond animals in towns to those that wander into buffer zones on the outskirts. Even before the cull guidance was expanded in April, large numbers of bears were being killed – a record 14,000 last fiscal year, or almost 40 a day.

Ms. Takii argued Nagano's coexistence programme offered a different path.

While direct comparisons are difficult, some figures appear to show it has helped limit dangerous encounters. Annual sightings have remained broadly stable at around 1,400 in recent years, while some northern prefectures have recorded sharp increases. Last year, Nagano recorded 11 bear-related incidents, including one death, compared with 59 encounters and four deaths in Akita further north and five fatalities in Iwate.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

It works — but we do not know how

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

The element X is one of the most effective mood stabilisers known, but after having been in use for decades, medical researchers still lack consensus about how exactly it works. Leading theories say it affects inositol signalling and inhibits the GSK-3 enzyme, but they haven't been able to explain all of X's effects. Name X.

QUESTION 2

The general form of _____ induce unconsciousness, amnesia, and immobility during surgery and have been used safely for over 150 years, yet scientists still lack a cohesive theory of how they work at the molecular level. Different forms of the drugs also seem to act through somewhat different molecular routes, yet succeed in inducing unconsciousness. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3

The BCS theory does a good job

of explaining conventional superconductivity. However, high-temperature superconductors that scientists found in compounds called Y in the 1980s still lack a complete and cogent theoretical explanation for how they superconduct. Name Y.

QUESTION #4

_____, a.k.a. Glucophage, is used worldwide as a first-line drug in the treatment of type II diabetes, yet scientists are still figuring out how it lowers blood glucose levels. Some leading ideas include the drug's effects on the gut microbiome and the mitochondrial complex I. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION #5

At sub-anesthetic doses, name the drug derived from phencyclidine — and which was used as surgical anesthesia during the Vietnam War — that can lift severe depression within hours, in dramatic contrast to the drugs called SSRIs. As with other therapies on this list, its full mechanism of action is still unclear.



Visual: Name the phenomenon depicted here as an aeroplane flies through coloured smoke. A complete analytical theory describing it is one of the Millennium Prize problems. NASA

Answers to August 27 quiz:

1. Businessman who drilled world's first commercial oil well – Ans: **Edwin Drake**
 2. Substance yielded along with crude oil, used to be flared off – Ans: **Natural gas**
 3. Components of hydraulic fracturing fluid – Ans: **Water and sand**
 4. Valve systems that prevented uncontrolled gushing of oil – Ans: **Blowout preventers**
 5. Machines called 'noddling donkeys' to mechanically lift oil – Ans: **Pump jacks**
- Visual: **Paul Thomas Anderson directed There Will Be Blood**

First contact:

Tamal Biswas | K.N. Viswanathan | Raj Sisodiya | Sachin Pant | Anan Rahim

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Orthodoxy redux

Religion is oft used as a tool to suppress women in the public sphere

Veteran Islamic cleric Kanthapuram A.P. Aboobacker Musliar’s directive to restrict Muslim women’s participation in public celebrations has unsettled Keralam because it strikes at a fundamental question: women’s right to participate in public life. This is not merely a quarrel over how Muslims should mark Prophet Muhammad’s 1,501st birth anniversary. It is a test of how far religious authority can intrude into the lives of women in a State that takes pride in its progressive social history. Kanthapuram says he is merely reminding followers of established religious norms. His supporters argue Milad celebrations have moved beyond mosques and madrasas into large public events, and that scholars have a duty to caution against such departures. That argument holds no weight. Communities have the right to preserve traditions and regulate religious practices, but they have to conform to the values enshrined in the Constitution. When women are told to remain at home because their presence could cause “chaos”, the issue is no longer about religious observance; it is at variance with constitutional equality and Keralam’s long struggle to expand the space in public life for women disadvantaged by social customs and religious traditions.

The Muslim community is not a monolith. It contains both orthodox and progressive currents. More Muslim women are breaking barriers in education, employment, politics and public life, but that progress is encountering a counter-current of renewed orthodoxy and social control. The CPI(M), Keralam’s main Opposition party and a decades-old ally of the Kanthapuram-led faction of Samastha Kerala Jamiyyathul Ulama, a body of Sunni scholars, has responded sharply. The Congress, which leads the ruling coalition, was largely guarded until Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan rubbished the decree as antediluvian. The Indian Union Muslim League’s silence is harder to defend. A party with an active women’s forum and a woman legislator for the first time in the State Assembly cannot equivocate when women’s right to public participation is open to challenge. Its caution may reflect political pressure over Waqf, *Vande Mataram* and PM-SHRI, or an attempt to improve ties with the Kanthapuram faction amid strained relations with the rival Samastha faction. Whatever the political calculation, silence carries a cost. Religious freedom does not confer on religious authorities the right to regulate women’s freedom of movement, association and degree of participation in society. During Onam, social media were awash with videos of young Muslim girls celebrating the harvest festival. Kanthapuram’s remarks drew criticism from a section of Muslim women on social media. Keralam cannot claim to be progressive while making exceptions for orthodoxy.

Many layers

Farmers need more storage facilities and better distribution networks

Since the 1960s, India has developed a balancing-act habit: between keeping food prices affordably low for consumers and assuring farmers of remunerative prices, with the state’s interventions focused on managing this volatility in the short term. This is also why the government banned onion exports from December 2023 to May 2024, then imposed a \$550/tonne minimum export price and a 40% export duty, reduced the duty to 20% in September 2024, and finally abolished it in April 2025. But erratic weather together with the lack of long-term relief has rendered the act increasingly awkward. From farmers’ point of view, the government often changes its mind after they have made important production-related decisions based on the expected price. On the other hand, during the bounteous *rabi* harvest, onion farmers in Maharashtra, the country’s principal supplier, had argued that the Centre’s procurement price of ₹12.35/kg would not cover the costs of cultivation. The Centre subsequently raised the price to up to ₹26.45/kg, but many farmers – including some who had had to sell at ₹1/kg earlier because of low quality and lack of storage, among other factors – were unable to capture the higher value, exposing the limits of intervening after prices have already collapsed and not reaching all farmers or grades of produce.

While the government has alluded to some price manipulation, the dominant issue remains that it keeps reacting instead of taking proactive measures, including improving storage options, maintaining a less erratic trade policy, moving stock more efficiently between regions, and protecting farmers against price shocks. The abnormal rainfall at the time of harvest and a 5%-7% drop in the *kharif* crop in Maharashtra, together with the well-known challenges associated with storing onions and maintaining large buffers, are simply among the pressures that highlighted the flaw this year. Further, Tamil Nadu’s targeted subsidy, to buy 1,000 tonnes of onions to distribute 1 kg per ration card at ₹35, will impose pressures on the Centre to maintain a steady supply. The move is commendably designed to discourage hoarding while allowing private retail prices to cool down. However, the State must also guard against the pitfalls of distributing onions through a dry-grain PDS network – its economic case could collapse if post-harvest losses, to which onion is more susceptible than, say, wheat or rice, exceed 10%-15% – and if the need arises to persist with the subsidy. Finally, if other States also adopt similar measures, the Central buffer could be quickly exhausted, more so given this year’s high storage losses of around 30%.

On August 25, 2026, in Beijing, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and China’s Foreign Minister Wang Yi held the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives (SRs) on the India-China boundary question. That evening’s readouts from both sides were anodyne and notably avoided a phrase that has dominated this discussion for a year: early harvest. A day later, the two sides released an “Eight Points of Outcomes and Consensus”. Point 3 restored and enhanced the phrase: the Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation and the Working Group on Border Management, set up under the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) a year ago, would “respectively advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation and Border Management”. Their first task, it adds, is to agree on their own terms of reference, one year after they were constituted, suggesting that whatever is being contemplated remains at an early stage

An uncertain Early Harvest

The phrase “Early and Substantial Harvest” is significant because it is India’s own coinage. When Beijing first proposed settling the Sikkim Sector alone, India’s considered response, around 2019, was a counter-proposal on an “Early and Substantial Harvest” covering the Sikkim Sector together with the entire Middle Sector, with the boundary delineated along the watershed. China rejected the proposal. In subsequent discussions on an “Early Harvest,” China reportedly agreed only to include the Sikkim Sector and some undisputed areas of the Middle Sector – a proposal that was unacceptable to India.

The exact Indian formulation has now resurfaced in a joint document. This could mean that Beijing has accepted India’s terms – which this writer doubts – as that would involve China giving up its claim to approximately 2,450 square kilometres of territory in the Middle Sector, all south of the watershed boundary (Barahoti, Giu-Kaurik, Nilang-Jadhang, Sangcha Malla, and Lapthal). It could equally mean something the Indian side had rejected earlier: an “agreement with holes”, a settlement nominally covering both sectors but confined to stretches where the claims already coincide, leaving the trijunctions and contested pockets of the Middle Sector undefined.

If that is the case, we will have the same asymmetric outcome as with a Sikkim-only settlement – India conceding ground where its position is strong, without any progress in the Eastern and Western Sectors, where China maintains its hardline position, “dong tiao xi rang”, meaning “meaningful adjustments by India in the East and corresponding concessions by China in the West”. It would also jettison a key provision (Article III) of the 2005 Agreement on



Ashok K. Kantha

Former Ambassador of India to China; Subhas Chandra Bose Chair Professor of International Relations at Chanakya University, Bengaluru, and the lead Indian negotiator for the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Boundary Settlement (2005)

India-China boundary talks suggest movement, but hard questions remain over strategic costs and concessions

Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary, which calls for a “package settlement ...covering all sectors of the India-China boundary”, opting instead to bank the easy gains immediately while leaving the hard issues open on China’s terms. The package clause exists precisely because the boundary’s four sectors are strategically interlinked, requiring cross-sector give and take.

No open-and-shut case

The Sikkim Sector is also not the open-and-shut case that some suggest. The two sides agree that the Anglo-Chinese Convention of 1890 is the “basis of the alignment” of the boundary in this sector. However, Article I of the Convention contains two stipulations that are mutually contradictory. Its first sentence makes the watershed crest the boundary, while its second names Mount Gipmochi as the starting point on the Bhutan frontier. Yet, British Indian maps of 1907 and 1913 placed the trijunction not at Gipmochi but roughly 6.5 kilometres to its north, on the true watershed crest. India and Bhutan read the watershed principle as controlling and place the trijunction at Batang La; China seizes on the literal reference to Gipmochi to push the trijunction southwards, onto the Jampheri Ridge. A Sikkim delimitation built on the 1890 text, unless it repudiates Gipmochi, would be read by Beijing as conceding the southern trijunction.

Even a trijunction-reserved settlement would strip India of the standing to counsel Bhutan against a bilateral deal, having itself settled out of turn nearby. China’s “package proposal” to Bhutan – relinquishing roughly 495 sq km of claims in the north in exchange for Bhutan ceding about 269 sq km in the northwest, including the Doklam Plateau – would gain fresh momentum, deepening China’s presence in the Chumbi Valley and opening a path to the Jampheri Ridge, from which the entire Siliguri Corridor, India’s sole overland link to its northeastern States, would come under direct observation. This is not hypothetical: since the 2017 Doklam standoff, China has spent years building roads, villages, and military facilities across western Bhutan, gaining de facto control over Doklam.

A genuine “Early and Substantial Harvest” requires three things. First, delineation must proceed on the highest-watershed principle across the entire stretch in both sectors, rather than selectively along segments where the two positions already converge, which would serve no purpose for India. Second, trijunction points, at Batang La and any comparable third-country-adjacent points in the Middle Sector, must be explicitly excluded from the Expert Group’s mandate and settled only in consultation with the country concerned, as stipulated in the 2012 Common Understanding between the two SRs. However, unless the highest-watershed principle is accepted, silence

Reducing India’s exposure to U.S. tariff risks



Himanshu Jaiswal

Consultant at the Centre for Social and Economic Progress, New Delhi

The Lindsey O. Graham Act puts India under pressure, but export diversification and domestic reforms can cushion shocks

the strategy has helped secure supplies, it carries diplomatic costs, particularly in managing ties with the United States, which seeks to strongly discourage these imports. The U.S. Russia Sanctions Act reflects this pressure.

On July 24, before the bill’s introduction, the U.S. imposed forced-labour tariffs on 60 countries, including India, under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974, imposing an additional 10% tariff, a replacement of the expired 10% duty under Section 122, on India. If the Russia Sanctions Act becomes law, India’s cumulative tariff could reach 110%, making it one of the most heavily tariffed countries. Such high tariffs could affect India’s price competitiveness in the U.S., a major export market, leading to economic losses. China’s cumulative tariff could reach 112.5%, as both countries are major importers of Russian crude.

Trade simulations and results

To analyse the trade dynamics and possible way forward for India, two global trade simulations were conducted using the GTAP dataset and model, a global general equilibrium model that captures global linkages and country-level shocks. The first (sanction scenario) models a 110% U.S. tariff on India, with other countries facing forced-labour tariffs and China facing 112.5%. The second (diversification scenario) applies the same tariffs while India pursues export diversification, proxied by a full India-European Union free trade agreement (FTA).

The simulation results suggest that the proposed U.S. sanctions could have adverse consequences for the Indian economy. Under the sanction scenario, India’s welfare declines by nearly \$47 billion, while GDP, output, domestic demand, exports, and imports all contract. Aggregate exports fall by 5.1% and imports by 5.2%, reflecting disrupted trade flows and weaker

on the trijunction will, on the ground, be filled in Beijing’s favour in Bhutan. Third, the terms of reference for the Expert Group must extend India’s 2019 proposal in good faith, rather than dilute it beyond recognition.

Several questions about these negotiations remain unanswered. The Chinese readout of August 25 reiterates a commitment to a “package” settlement, but how will that commitment be reconciled with a piecemeal approach to settlement? How is the setting up of an Expert Group on Delimitation consistent with the instructions given to the SRs in Article X of the 2005 Agreement, which require them to “continue consultations in an earnest manner with the objective of arriving at an agreed framework for a boundary settlement, which will provide the basis for the delineation and demarcation of the India-China boundary to be subsequently undertaken by civil and military officials and surveyors of the two sides”? There is no agreed framework yet, but it is proposed to commence the process of “delimitation”, a term that the Chinese use interchangeably with “demarcation”. Indeed, the 2005 Agreement does not use the term “delimitation” at all. Will the SRs earnestly pursue negotiations on the “agreed framework”, or will they, in effect, leave it in abeyance while officials grapple with a partial delimitation exercise without such a framework? The other elements of the Eight Points – additional meeting points and hotlines for the General Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle Sectors, continued pilgrimage and border trade, and a September meeting on trans-border rivers – are useful, incremental confidence-building measures. But they belong to a different track from boundary settlement and should not be conflated in public discussion.

The Eight Points are silent on the Medog County project on the Yarlung Tsangpo River, while referring to both sides agreeing to “maintain communication on (trans-border river) issues, including hydrological data sharing and renewal of the relevant MoUs”, without reporting any progress. The September meeting should convey India’s concerns about the project – the world’s largest hydropower plant – being built close to the border in the Eastern Sector, in a highly earthquake-prone zone, a risk underscored by the flash floods in Nepal on August 26.

Avoid optics

Two points bear reiteration. First, the 2005 agreement – the only substantive outcome of 23 years of SR talks – must not be diluted; China has sought to reinterpret and undermine it since its conclusion. Second, Indian negotiators must guard against the temptation to project contrived progress. Diplomacy that trades long-term strategic interests for short-term optics is self-defeating.

The U.S. Senate recently passed the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, imposing sanctions and authorising additional tariffs and other restrictions related to Russia. Most concerning is a provision authorising tariffs of up to 100% on countries among the five largest importers of Russian crude oil or natural gas if they knowingly make new purchases after enactment. Though it still awaits House approval, enactment could have serious implications for India’s economic interests.

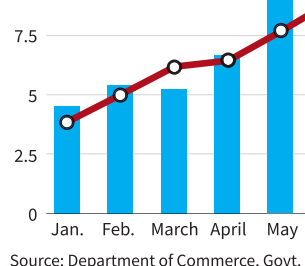
The Russian oil dilemma

India has diversified its energy supplies in recent years to reduce its crude import bill and gain strategic advantage amid global uncertainty, driving a sharp rise in Russian crude imports. Before the Russia-Ukraine conflict, Russian crude accounted for just 2% of India’s imports; it is now roughly half.

In 2026 alone, imports nearly doubled from 4.54 MMT in January to 8.96 MMT in May. While

India’s crude import from Russia

Quantity (MMT)
Share in total crude imports (%)



Source: Department of Commerce, Govt. of India

Impact of tariffs and export diversification

	Sanction scenario	Diversification scenario
Welfare (\$ billion)	-46.6	26.3
Change in GDP (%)	-0.02	0.01
Sectoral output (%)	-1.9	1.2
Domestic demand (%)	-1.8	1
Aggregate export (%)	-5.1	3.1
Aggregate import (%)	-5.2	2.6

Source: Writer’s analysis using GTAP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The north-south lens

The main article (Editorial page, September 2) risks turning a complex federal question into a simplistic north-versus-south narrative. India’s political influence has never been determined by geography alone; it reflects population, electoral mandates, governance, economic contribution and the ability of States to build national

coalitions. The southern States continue to exercise considerable political, economic and institutional influence, while several leaders from the region have shaped national policy. Portraying elected southern governments as “suppliant” or “submissive” is subjective and needlessly polarising. Delimitation deserves rigorous constitutional

debate, but framing it primarily as northern domination may deepen regional divisions rather than strengthen India’s federal compact.

Venkat Parthasarathy, Hyderabad

Austerity call

The call to citizens of the country to avoid unnecessary foreign travel and destination weddings

abroad to conserve foreign exchange would carry greater weight if accompanied by restraint from those at the top. Overseas travel by national leaders may often be necessary in the public interest, but when citizens are asked to limit their foreign expenditure, similar prudence from those in positions of authority would strengthen the message.

Leadership is not only about asking citizens to sacrifice, but also about setting an example.

Tharcus S. Fernando, Chennai

Football’s great artist

Legend Lionel Messi’s retirement from international football marks the end of one of modern sport’s most extraordinary chapters. For two decades,

he transformed football into an art form, carrying Argentina’s expectations through years of heartbreak and criticism. He leaves the international stage not only as a statistical giant, but also as a symbol of humility, grace and vision.

R. Sivakumar, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The views expressed are personal

River-linking is not the solution

The Union Minister for Home Affairs Amit Shah's speech at the Southern Zonal Council's meeting last month in Mamallapuram has provided a few takeaways on the contentious issue of water sharing. His emphasis on the need for an early resolution of water-related issues in the southern region appears well meaning but it is easier said than done. He had also talked about linking major rivers from the Brahmaputra to the Godavari and the Cauvery, an option that, according to Mr. Shah, can ensure that India faces no water shortage for 100 years.

However, water issues are not that easy to solve. This is evident from the Centre's response to Tamil Nadu's demand for the constitution of a tribunal to adjudicate the Pennaiyar river water dispute. Aggrieved over the "violation" of the 1892 inter-State agreement by Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, in November 2019, requested the Centre to establish a tribunal. It had also moved the Supreme Court with the same demand. Since then, two negotiation committees have been formed and 11 meetings held. Eventually, the top court, this February, directed the Centre to form the tribunal within a month and, later, extended the deadline by six months.

Still, the adjudicatory body is yet to be put in place. Meanwhile, the Centre asked the court whether the Pennaiyar dispute could be referred to the Mahadayi Water Dispute Tribunal instead of constituting a new tribunal. This suggestion defies logic as there is nothing in common between the two



T. Ramakrishnan

disputes. Moreover, the Interstate River Water Disputes Act, 1956 does not permit it. This suggestion in the Pennaiyar case gives the impression that the Centre is not keen on expeditiously implementing a judicial verdict in an inter-State river dispute. To cite one more example, the Central government has not yet replied to Tamil Nadu's demand, in March this year, to constitute a tribunal on the Mekedatu dam project proposed by Karnataka.

A complex problem
Given this background, one need not delve much into the complications that would entail by the inter-linking of rivers. Proponents of river linking, including Tamil Nadu, have been saying that the idea is not to disturb the natural flow of any river but to divert a portion of the surplus water. Many experts are not convinced about this argument as they are worried that once the linking is allowed, regions that benefit may become vociferous in demanding water even in times of distress, eventually depriving original beneficiaries of their quota. This is apart from the concerns over the possible adverse consequences on ecology. In fact, Keralam has been stoutly opposing the Pamba-Achankovil-Vaippar link proposal, which, if implemented, the State says, will affect the Vembanad wetland system, where the Pamba and Achankovil rivers drain. However, the National Water Development Agency says that it has accounted for improving the flow of rivers in lean periods.

In the last 130-odd years, the country has seen only a handful of inter-basin transfer projects, most of which are in south India

In the last 130-odd years, the country has seen only a handful of inter-basin transfer projects, most of which are in south India

Mullaperiyar dam, the Parambikulam-Aliyar project, the Krishna Water Supply Project, and the Indira Gandhi Canal Project are regarded as successful examples of inter-basin transfer of river waters.

After the Bharatiya Janata Party's return to power in 2014, the Union government formed a Special Committee for Interlinking of Rivers, which has held over two dozen meetings since then. Needless to say, there has not been much headway.

However, in 2024, Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone for the ₹44,000 crore Ken-Betwa Link Project. This has now led to agitations by the tribal populations in Chhatarpur.

What the governments, both at the Centre and in States, and civil society should focus on is demand side management, instead of perpetually looking for supply side interventions. With land becoming scarcely available and resistance growing among people when it comes to land acquisition, the days of implementing mega irrigation projects are almost over. The priority has to be towards conserving what is available and using it judiciously. A massive programme of sensitising and incentivising farmers on the optimal use of water has to be launched. Indiscriminate extraction of groundwater, facilitated by schemes of free electricity for agriculture in many States, is paving the way for ecological disaster and has to be curbed immediately. Unless water conservation becomes the mantra of all the stakeholders and is practised genuinely, disputes will be the norm.

ramakrishnan.t@thehindu.co.in

Mental health must anchor public health

India stands at a defining moment in its journey towards the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. Under the Healthcare for All pillar, the government has rightly prioritised strengthening Ayushman Bharat, expanding primary healthcare, reducing out-of-pocket expenditure, and promoting preventive care. Yet there is one element that cuts across all these ambitions and determines their success: mental health.

Mental health is not a niche concern. It influences educational attainment, workforce participation, social cohesion, and physical health outcomes. A healthier and more productive India cannot be built without placing mental well-being at the centre of public health.

Major implications
The scale of the challenge is substantial. Mental illness affects one in seven Indians, with nearly 200 million people living with a diagnosable mental health condition. The contribution of mental disorders to India's total disease burden has doubled over the past three decades. Yet the national treatment gap remains 84.5%, meaning that more than four out of five people who need care do not receive it. The reasons are well known. India has only 0.3 psychiatrists per 1,00,000 population, alongside significant shortages in clinical psychologists, psychiatric social workers, and psychiatric nurses. These shortages are the result of decades during which mental health received insufficient attention, both in India and globally.

Mental disorders significantly increase the risk



Indu Bhushan

Founding CEO of India's National Health Authority and Ayushman Bharat



Anisha Padukone

CEO of The Live Love Laugh Foundation

of chronic diseases, while chronic diseases in turn increase the risk of mental illness. More than 60% of people attending primary care facilities have a diagnosable mental disorder. Rates of anxiety and depression are substantially higher among people living with diabetes, hypertension, tuberculosis, and HIV/AIDS. Ignoring mental health, therefore, undermines efforts to control non-communicable diseases and reduce healthcare expenditure.

The economic implications are equally compelling. A 2025 modelling study by researchers from PGIMER and NIMHANS estimated that integrating universal depression screening into India's primary healthcare system could generate net savings of ₹291 billion to ₹482 billion annually, equivalent to as much as 0.32% of GDP. Mental health is not a social welfare issue alone – it is also a human capital investment and an economic growth strategy.

The encouraging news is that India has already built many of the foundations required for transformation. More than 1.73 lakh sub-centres and primary health centres have been converted into Ayushman Bharat Arogya Mandirs, with mental healthcare included among the essential service packages. The District Mental Health Programme now covers more than 90% of districts. Tele-MANAS, launched in 2022, has expanded across all States and Union Territories.

Three main priorities
The task now is not to start from scratch. It is to build on this foundation at scale. First, one must empower

If India is to become a truly developed nation by 2047, mental health must move from the margins of public policy to its centre

frontline health workers to become the backbone of community mental healthcare. India's one million ASHA workers represent the world's largest community health workforce. Evidence from Madhya Pradesh and other States demonstrates that, with appropriate training and supervision, ASHAs can successfully identify, support, and refer individuals with common mental disorders. Expanding this model through validated screening tools, digital learning platforms, and performance-linked incentives could expand access to care.

Second, India must invest more systematically in community-based care. Models such as Zimbabwe's Friendship Bench, Atmiyata in India, and programmes implemented by The Live Love Laugh Foundation demonstrate that trained community workers can bridge the gap between awareness and treatment, particularly in rural and underserved populations. These approaches improve access and reduce costs, and deserve wider adoption and funding. Third, the country must fully realise the promise of financial protection. Extending outpatient mental health benefits under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana and strengthening the implementation of insurance parity as per the Mental Healthcare Act, 2017, would make mental healthcare affordable for millions who currently go without care.

If India is to become a truly developed nation by 2047, mental health must move from the margins of public policy to its centre.

Decoding Russia's reliance on Indian petroleum products

Ukraine's recent relentless attacks on Russia's oil refineries has led the country to rely on India for petroleum imports

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis

Recent Ukrainian attacks on Russia's oil refineries has resulted in the latter importing refined petroleum products from India in significant quantities for the first time, at least since the Russia-Ukraine war started in February 2022.

As per multiple media reports, including one by the *Press Trust of India*, Indian refiners sent about one million barrels over the last two months, alongside Turkey and Morocco. Russia's import of petroleum products from India has remained negligible in the past, accounting for less than one per cent of India's petroleum exports. The bulk of exports went to countries like the Netherlands, Australia and the UAE (**Chart 1**).

Though the Indian government's export and import-related data for the last two months is yet to be released, reports have confirmed that the country's export of refined petroleum products to Russia has sharply increased in the last two months. This has tilted the huge imbalance that existed between the two countries in oil trade, albeit marginally. India continues to remain hugely dependent on Russia for crude.

One-fourth of India's petroleum imports since January 2022 were from Russia and this number remained high before U.S. President Donald Trump imposed additional tariffs on India in October 2025 for buying crude from Russia.

Though this resulted in India sharply cutting down its crude import from Russia, the imports resumed in full swing soon after. In fact, after the U.S. and Israel launched a war with Iran in February this year, the former did a U-turn in its stance and tacitly encouraged Russian crude supplies into the market to negate the impact of Iran's blockade in the Strait of Hormuz.

Chart 2 shows how Russia accounted for nearly one-third (31.6%) of India's crude imports as of June 2026. India imported \$531 million worth of crude from Russia in June 2026, which is roughly double that of its import from the country in January 2022, a month before Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Amid Ukraine's continued targeting of Russia's oil refining infrastructure, the Russian Federation's Deputy Prime Minister Alexander Novak said in July that the country would begin importing oil products to help stabilise the domestic market.

Consistent attacks

According to the International Strategic Action Network for Security, there were at least 17 attacks on 16 different oil refineries in Russia. Eight attacks were targeted at oil depots and oil pumping stations in July (**Chart 3**). Though reliable data on similar attacks in August are not available yet, they seem to have continued at the same rate, resulting in petrol and diesel shortages.

Data from the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) show that Russia's refinery crude throughput went from about 5.18 million barrels per day in Q12026 (January to March) in the beginning of the year, to about 3.88 million barrels per day in Q32026. The attacks also seem to have contributed to a surge in crude exports from Russia, as unplanned refinery outages diverted higher volumes of crude to the export market. India, which ranks fourth in oil-refining capacity in the world, has utilised Russia's sudden demand to export refined petroleum products, mainly from private refineries (**Chart 4**). Considering the time it would take for Russia to bring its refining capacity back to its earlier capacity, the surge in exports could continue, which will help India in easing its pressure on foreign exchange in the coming months.



A refining relationship

The data were sourced from India's Ministry of Commerce and Industry, the International Strategic Action Network for Security, the Statistical Review of World Energy BP, and the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries. With inputs from Gandla Sneha, who is interning with The Hindu Data Team

CHART 1: Russia's share in India's petroleum exports has traditionally been less than 1% (not visible in the chart)

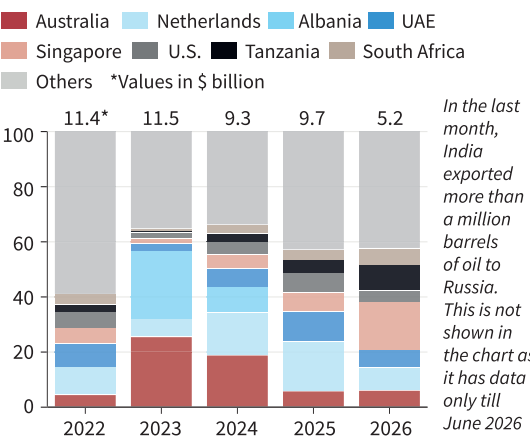


CHART 2: Russia accounted for more than one-fourth of India's total crude imports since January 2022

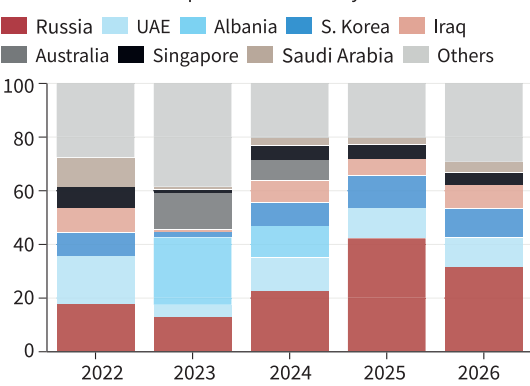


CHART 3: A total of 17 attacks were recorded against 16 different oil refineries in Russia in July

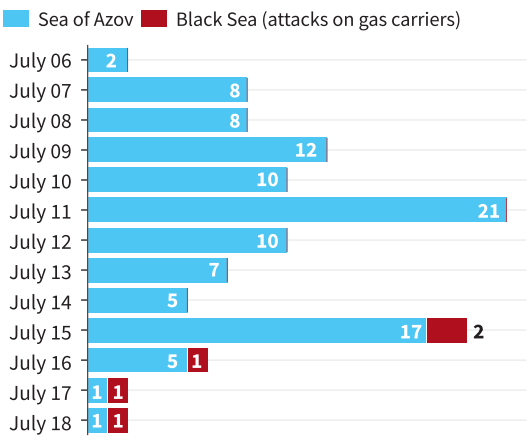
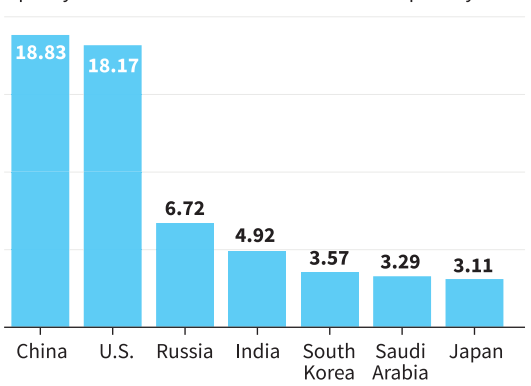


CHART 4: The seven countries with the highest oil refining capacity in the world. Values in million barrels per day



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The *Hindu*.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 3, 1976

Tip-off leads to underground vault

Madras, September 2: Sixteen exquisite bronze idols and 17 puja utensils all valued at Rs. one crore have been recovered from an underground vault in the ancient Kalyanasundarar Temple in Nallur, Papanasam taluk in Thanjavur district. The temple is under the control of the Tiruvaduthurai Adheenam.

Officials of the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department and State Directorate of Archaeology, led by Dr. R. Nagaswami, Director of Archaeology, acting on a hint thrown by the temple executive searched and found the vault. A representative of the Tiruvaduthurai Adheenam was present during the search. The Math's records indicate that these valuable images and jewels had been deposited in the safe vault in 1942.

These rare pieces of art were retrieved earlier this week after securing an order from the State Government to rummage the underground cell in the temple precincts.

Apart from the discovery of the valuable pieces from the subterranean chamber, this probe has given a clue to the traditional method of safeguarding precious idols and ornaments of a temple and the care bestowed on preservation of art forms.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 3, 1926

Slavery in Burma frontier

Rangoon, September 2: *The Rangoon Gazette* says that the successful emancipation of slaves in Hukawng valley last season will, it is said, be followed this cold season by an expedition to that part of unadministered territory between Malikha and Nmaikha rivers, north of their junction to the Irrawaddy river and locally known as the triangle where the same system of slavery as existed in Hukawng valley still prevails. The triangles though not as extensive a territory as Hukawng valley, is more densely populated and the number of slaves to be liberated will be more numerous. It is expected that Mr. J.T.O. Barnard, Deputy Commissioner, Burma, Frontier Service, who was principally responsible for the arrangements for the emancipation of the slaves in the Hukawng valley will be placed on this duty and in charge of the expedition. *The Gazette's* statement is yet unconfirmed.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount mobilised by banks in deposits from Indian diaspora

127.23 in \$ billion. India attracted a whopping USD 127.23 billion in Foreign Currency Non-Resident (FCNR-B) deposits under the Reserve Bank's special USD-INR forex swap facility till August 31, the closing date. The RBI's special USD-INR forex swap facility was launched on June 8, 2026. PTI

Length of Manipur's border with Myanmar that has been fenced

55 in kilometres. Manipur Home Minister Govindas Konthoujam on Wednesday said that nearly 55 km out of 398 km of the State's international border with Myanmar has been fenced. Mr. Konthoujam was responding to a calling attention motion raised by Congress MLA K. Ranjit Singh on the "reported proposal for a land swap deal between India and Myanmar". PTI

Number of dengue cases recorded in Delhi till August 29

311 As many as 311 cases of dengue, 119 of malaria and 22 of chikungunya have been recorded in Delhi till August 29 this year, while no death has been reported due to any of the diseases. Delhi recorded its highest monthly tally of dengue cases this year in August, with 90 infections reported during the month, a Municipal Corporation of Delhi report says. PTI

Number of special trains operated during Onam season this year

180 As many as 180 special train services were operated in the Thiruvananthapuram Division during the Onam festive season this year, carrying an additional 2,45,823 passengers, railway officials said here on Wednesday. The division recorded an overall punctuality of 94.67% in August this year, compared to 91% during the same month last year. PTI

Applications received for police recruitment in Himachal Pradesh

98 in thousands. The State Public Service Commission has received over 98,000 applications for police constable recruitment till September 1, 2026, Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu told the Assembly on Wednesday. He said the September 5 deadline for application would not be extended. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Constitutional faultlines in FCRA Bill

The FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026 provides for a 'Designated Authority' to oversee the management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets when an organisation's FCRA certificate is cancelled or ceases to exist; raising questions about the extent of State intervention and the need for sufficient safeguards against overreach

LETTER & SPIRIT

Thajaswini C.B.
Siddharth Dev Prasad

It is hard to deny that the state has a legitimate concern in regulating foreign contributions in India, as foreign donations raise issues concerning national security, transparency in democracy, and public accountability. For decades, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act has been the instrument through which this interest has been pursued. However, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 raises a different question altogether. It goes beyond regulating foreign contributions, to the extent to which the state may intervene in assets and institutional activities associated with them.

The fundamental issue, therefore, is not a debate between civil society and national security. It is about where the State, in pursuit of its legitimate regulatory goal, may cross the boundary from regulating foreign contributions to exercising undue executive control over the institutions that receive them.

The Bill's most important aspect is a statutory framework for the vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets through a 'Designated Authority'. Where an organisation's FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered or ceases to exist, including due to non-renewal, the Central government may appoint an authority to which the foreign contribution and assets created from it may vest provisionally. The measure is framed as an accountability mechanism to prevent the diversion or abuse of such properties.

Expansion of statutory consequences However, the constitutional difficulty lies elsewhere.

The FCRA has always empowered the state to scrutinise foreign funding. If there are any violations in this regard, registrations can be withdrawn,



Opposition MPs protest in New Delhi on April 1, demanding the withdrawal of the FCRA Amendment Bill.

cancellation can follow continuing non-compliance, and penalties can attach to the diversion or misappropriation of foreign contributions. The Bill, however, represents a significant expansion of the statutory consequences that can follow the loss of FCRA registration. Importantly, the existing FCRA law already contains a provision for vesting assets created from foreign funds upon cancellation. What is new is the detailed statutory framework for their provisional vesting, possession, management, restoration and ultimately, permanent vesting and disposal.

In case of cancellation, surrender, or cessation of registration, the government may, through the Designated Authority, take possession of and manage assets created from foreign contributions and, where considered necessary or expedient in the public interest, undertake the management of the concerned organisation's activities. This is not merely a change in administrative policy; it raises a constitutional question about the extent to which a statute regulating foreign contributions may permit executive authorities to assume possession and, in specified circumstances, management of institutional assets and activities.

Even if the dichotomy between ownership and custody may have some legal relevance, its practical consequences are not. An entity whose success is dependent on the continuity of management will place greater emphasis on control than ownership. Ownership may remain formally undisturbed, but a change in management control fundamentally alters the relationship between the institution and the state. A hospital, school or laboratory is not made effective by ownership alone; it depends on its independence to administer, for charitable ends, what it owns.

Evaluation of proportionality

This is where the doctrine of constitutional proportionality may be relevant. The Supreme Court has repeatedly held that even where the state pursues a legitimate objective, the means it adopts must bear a reasonable connection to that objective and must maintain an appropriate balance between the public purpose and the burden imposed on rights. The amendment raises difficult questions when measured against the said rationale. If the consequence of losing FCRA registration is the provisional vesting of assets in, and potentially the

management of institutional activities by a government-appointed authority, the safeguards attending that transfer must be commensurately robust.

Therefore, the Bill warrants scrutiny of the extent of the discretion delegated to the executive, the safeguards governing its exercise and the standards applicable to decisions concerning possession, management, and permanent vesting. The Bill provides for the restoration of assets when registration is obtained, renewed, or restored within the prescribed period, as well as mechanisms for revision and judicial appeal. The constitutional question is whether these safeguards are sufficiently clear, timely and effective.

This concern becomes more significant against the broader regulatory landscape. Over the past decade, thousands of FCRA registrations have ceased to operate for reasons ranging from non-renewal to alleged statutory violations. While many regulatory actions may be justified, the Bill may increase the consequences arising from the cessation of registration. What might previously have been limited to the loss of eligibility to receive foreign funds could, under the proposed framework, extend to provisional management and, if registration is not restored within the prescribed period, permanent vesting and disposal of assets.

None of this suggests that the government lacks the authority to strengthen financial oversight or ensure that funds from abroad are used for lawful and proper ends. But in a constitutional order, any regime that reaches into the management of civil society's institutional infrastructure must operate within clear legislative standards.

Ultimately, the constitutional question posed by the FCRA Amendment Bill is not whether foreign contributions should be regulated, but how far the state may go in regulating institutions and their assets. (Thajaswini C.B. is an advocate practising before the Supreme Court, Madras and Delhi High Courts. Siddharth Dev Prasad is a 4th year law student at Gujarat National Law University.)

THE GIST

The FCRA has always empowered the state to scrutinise foreign funding. The amendment Bill, however, represents a significant expansion of the statutory consequences that can follow the loss of FCRA registration.

Therefore, the Bill warrants scrutiny of the extent of the discretion delegated to the executive, the safeguards governing its exercise and the standards applicable to decisions concerning possession, management, and permanent vesting.

Can jurists be appointed as Supreme Court judges?

Why has the provision allowing distinguished jurists to be appointed as SC judges remained unused?

Aaratrika Bhaumik

The story so far:

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday questioned why a constitutional provision allowing a "distinguished jurist" to be appointed as a judge of the Supreme Court has remained unused for more than 76 years. Addressing the 13th convocation of National Law University, Delhi's LL.M. programme, Justice Bhuyan pointed out that Article 124(3) of the Constitution permits the appointment of a person who, in the President's opinion, is a "distinguished jurist" as a Supreme Court judge. However, no legal academic has so far been elevated to the top court under this provision.

What does the Constitution stipulate?

Article 124(3) of the Constitution lays down three routes through which a

person may qualify for appointment as a Supreme Court judge – a person must have served as a High Court judge for at least five years, practised as an advocate of a High Court for at least 10 years, or be, in the opinion of the President, a "distinguished jurist".

The provision, however, does not define who qualifies as a "distinguished jurist" or prescribe any minimum period of professional experience for such a person. Its inclusion as a separate category nevertheless indicates that the framers contemplated a route to the Supreme Court beyond the conventional pathways of judicial service and legal practice, potentially opening the door to eminent legal scholars and academics.

What do Constituent Assembly debates reflect?

The "distinguished jurist" category was added to the list of persons eligible for

appointment to the Supreme Court in the draft Constitution. The Constituent Assembly debates reflect that this was intended to bring diversity in professional backgrounds among those appointed to the Bench of the Supreme Court.

Moving the amendment on May 24, 1949, Constituent Assembly member H.V. Kamath said it sought "to open a wider field of choice" for Supreme Court appointments. He noted that persons with "outstanding legal and juristic learning" were "not necessarily confined to judges or advocates", pointing to the selection of judges of the International Court of Justice on similar terms.

The Constituent Assembly debates also referred to the appointment of Felix Frankfurter to the U.S. Supreme Court. In 1939, President Franklin D. Roosevelt appointed Frankfurter, who had been a professor at Harvard Law School for 25 years, as an Associate Justice of the U.S.

Supreme Court. Justice Frankfurter went on to become a noted advocate of the doctrine of judicial restraint – the principle that courts should respect the domain of the elected legislature and the executive, and exercise restraint in interfering with their decisions.

Assembly member M. Ananthasayanam Ayyangar cited Justice Frankfurter's appointment as a "novel experiment" that had worked well, noting that legal expertise was not confined to practising lawyers or judges.

Can a 'distinguished jurist' be appointed as a High Court judge?

The Constituent Assembly had also considered allowing "distinguished jurists" to be appointed as High Court judges. On June 7, 1949, Professor Shibban Lal Saksena moved an amendment proposing their inclusion among those eligible for appointment to a High Court. The proposal, however, was not accepted.

Nearly three decades later, the Constitution (Forty-second Amendment) Act, 1976, enacted during the Emergency, amended Article 217, which lays down the qualifications for appointment as a High Court judge. The amendment allowed a person who was, in the opinion of the President, a "distinguished jurist" to be appointed to a High Court. The provision came into force in January 1977 but was omitted by the Constitution (Forty-fourth

Amendment) Act, 1978.

What limits the use of this provision?

Despite being part of the Constitution since its inception, the provision has never been invoked. Supreme Court judges have overwhelmingly been appointed from among High Court judges, with only 11 advocates directly elevated from the Bar.

The appointment process itself may also help explain why the provision has remained unused, since a jurist would first have to be recommended by the Supreme Court Collegium. Legal scholar Upendra Baxi, whose possible appointment to the court never materialised, described the provision as a "dead issue" in a 2015 interview with LiveLaw.

Another concern is that legal academics may lack courtroom and procedural experience. However, full-time law teachers themselves face restrictions on practising as advocates. Under Rule 49 of the Bar Council of India Rules, an advocate who takes up full-time salaried employment must cease to practise while such employment continues. In 2019, the Consortium of National Law Universities sought a relaxation of this restriction to allow full-time faculty to practise in courts and bridge the divide between "law in books" and "law in action".

BOOK EXTRACT



Fisherwomen cast a large traditional fishing net into the Indravati river on the outskirts of Jagdalpur in Bastar district, Chhattisgarh. PTI

A colonial gaze: how the British imagined Bastar and its people

Colonial accounts portrayed Bastar as a primitive, isolated woodland whose inhabitants were ‘rude and barbarous,’ while a flawed census produced wildly unreliable population figures and recorded a plethora of colourful yet inaccurate professions

Shantanu Nandan Sharma

For years, Bastar remained an enigma to the British, who erroneously and conveniently dismissed it as a mysterious woodland inhabited by cannibals, painting it as an island of primitiveness amidst civilisations. In his enthusiasm to author a two-volume work on India, East India Company official Henry Harpur Spry went so far as to describe the people of Bastar as those who ‘sacrifice and eat their fellow creatures’.

Spread of misinformation

Consider this: Spry never set foot in Bastar, relying instead on hearsay from Company officers like Captain Crawford of the Bengal Artillery, who oversaw Chhattisgarh. Spry’s armchair account reads more like lengthy chatter rather than a valuable historical document. Further, there is no evidence to suggest that Crawford himself had any first-hand experience in Bastar. It is important to put it on record that Spry also made a glaring mistake on Bastar when he called its Rajput Raja a Gond. This mistake was possibly carried over from the past. While translating the *Tarikh-i-Firishta*, a medieval Persian history of the Deccan with intriguing references to the Bastar of 1610-11, John Briggs added an asterisk to the Bastar raja, mistakenly labelling him as a Gond chief.

The isolation of Bastar fostered the spread of misinformation. A report from the East India Company in 1812, for

example, provided a skewed perspective of the area and the people therein. The inhabitants were described as ‘rude and barbarous’, yet they were paradoxically praised for the staunch defence of their ‘ancient rightful inheritance’ - the lowlands. The report says that they, ‘although rude and barbarous, may yet be denominated warlike, as they have always distinguished themselves bold, persevering champions of the great law of nature’.

It further adds: ‘Being driven to their wild unwholesome fastness, among the mountains, they frequently descend in harvest time, into the lowlands, to dispute the produce of their ancient rightful inheritance with their present possessors...’ Clearly, the report’s author had not visited the territory.

Counting the people

The first attempt to quantify Bastar’s population came on November 5, 1866 during a census in the Central Provinces. This inaugural headcount yielded a figure of 2,69,684. However, the census was plagued by significant anomalies. The administration faced a dilemma when the next census in 1872 showed an inexplicable 70 per cent drop in the population, bringing the total down to 78,856. The breakdown of this figure included 29,060 Hindus, 1,704 Muslims, and a substantial category of 48,092 classified as ‘others’.

A deadly combination of cholera and famine ravaged central India in 1869, undoubtedly impacting Bastar. However,

this alone would not explain the population plunge – a staggering 1,90,828 residents vanishing in just six years. The numbers reeked of error.

J.W. Neill, officiating secretary to the Central Provinces’ chief commissioner, echoed these concerns in his report on the 1872 census. He pointed out glaring inconsistencies: The 1866 Bastar figures were likely mere estimates based on area, while the 1872 census, despite claiming a more rigorous method, also appeared flawed, as in many villages ‘the children were not enumerated’. The report quotes comments from the deputy commissioner of Upper Godavari district, under whose jurisdiction Bastar fell for census purposes.

Neill’s report continued to expose the flaws of the 1872 census in Bastar. While forms and instructions reached the raja, ‘there is no means of knowing whether houses were numbered or lists of inhabitants taken previous to the night of the Census’. Some areas, such as Jagdalpur, Bhopalpatnam and Bijapur, showed decent efforts, but the rest carried errors.

Most alarmingly, children under twelve were entirely omitted. While the Central Provinces overall saw a modest increase (from 9.06 million to 9.25 million), Bastar’s dramatic decline remained an enigma. In the census exercise of early British days, a headcount was conducted on a single day.

The 1872 census wasn’t just plagued by regional discrepancies; there were some structural errors too. The sheer number

of categories (caste, occupation, race, religion, remarks, etc. – a whopping nineteen) gave printers nightmares. Worse yet, a lack of training on open-ended questions led to a plethora of colourful yet inaccurate professions across the Central Provinces. Imagine finding entries like ‘con man’, ‘pimp’, ‘prostitute’, ‘idiot’, and ‘thief’ – a reflection more on the confusion of the enumerators than the reality of the population.

Neill’s report candidly highlighted the hilarious mishaps. He blamed some of the bizarre entries on overzealous enumerators who seemed determined to write something or the other in the occupancy column against every individual. Infants, for instance, were listed as ‘sucking’, children as simply ‘playing’, and newcomers to a village as ‘guests’.

Further confusion arose with the term *pesha-i-khud*, loosely translated as self-employed. Its frequent appearance left senior officers scratching their heads, unsure of the specific occupations it indicated. Neill even documented the enumerators’ struggle to differentiate between lunatics and idiots, wryly noting ‘it having been impossible to separate them, as the enumerators did not appreciate the distinction between the two classes’. (Excerpted with permission from Hachette India from Shantanu Nandan Sharma’s *Rebel Bastar: History, Maoism and the Search for Answers in India’s Heartland*)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between “cousin” and “half brother”? (N. Vardhan, Chennai)

The children of your father’s/ mother’s sister or brother are your “cousins”. In other words, your uncle’s kids or your aunt’s kids are your cousins. For most native speakers of English, cousins are what we in India call “first cousins”. In India, however, we have a tendency to introduce anyone who is distantly related to us as “my cousin”. Native speakers of English do not do this.

A “half brother” is someone who shares the same father or mother as you. In other words, if you have a half brother, it implies that you either have a stepfather or a stepmother.

What is the meaning of “on the qui vive”? (A. Umar, Kadayanallur)

First, let’s deal with the pronunciation. “Qui” is pronounced like the word “key” and “ive” in “vive” sounds like the word “eve”.

When you say that someone is “on the qui vive”, what you are implying is that he/she is alert; he/she is watching very carefully. This is what the expression means in English.

Geetha is always on the qui vive for bargains.

The soldiers were on the qui vive for another assault.

What is the difference between an “escort” and a “convoy”? (P. Parshuram, Secunderabad)

An “escort” is something or someone that is given to an individual as a mark of respect or as a form of protection. For example, Ministers in our country always have bodyguards surrounding them. The bodyguards are their escorts; they go wherever the Minister goes. Similarly, when an actress attends a party, she usually has an escort. When Hema Malini was young, her mother escorted her to most parties.

A “convoy”, on the other hand, refers to the vehicles that accompany someone important. Whenever a Chief Minister goes somewhere, he/she usually has about ten or fifteen cars following him/her. These cars are part of the convoy. Unlike the word “escort”, a convoy is usually used to refer to things (cars, lorries, ships, etc); the word is not used to refer to people.

What is the origin of the term “Molotov cocktail”? (M. R. Hareesh, Taliparamba)

Let me begin by telling you that this “cocktail” is no drink. A “Molotov cocktail” is a homemade firebomb! It usually consists of an inflammable liquid in a bottle to which a wick is attached. The wick is then lit and the bottle is thrown at someone or something. The result? The bottle explodes and the object catches fire. We see a lot of such bombs used by the villains in our regional films.

“Molotov cocktail” is named after V.M. Molotov, the man who was the Foreign Minister of the Soviet Union during World War II. When the Nazis invaded Russia during the Second World War, the Russian civilians used this cocktail quite successfully to destroy the German tanks. *Published in The Hindu on November 11, 2001*

THE DAILY QUIZ

A look at Lionel Messi’s international career in the wake of the Argentine football legend’s retirement

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1

In which year and where did Lionel Messi win the Olympic Gold and the Under-20 World Cup?

QUESTION 2

How many goals and assists did Messi net in his 207-match career for ‘La Albiceleste’?

QUESTION 3

Messi had a senior international debut to forget on August 17, 2005, because he was shown a straight red card, less than a minute after coming on in the 63rd minute, for an accidental elbow to an opponent.

Against which European team did this happen?

QUESTION 4

Which final heartbreak prompted Messi’s first international retirement in June 2016?

QUESTION 5

Messi holds the record for most major tournament goals in men’s history with how many goals?

QUESTION 6

With whom does Messi share the record for FIFA World Cup appearances (six in total)?

QUESTION 7

Against which South American country has he netted the most international goals (11)?



Visual question: In this image, Messi is celebrating the triumph in which tournament? REUTERS

Questions and answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:

1. This British constitutional initiative provided the framework for the formation of the Interim Government. **Ans: The Cabinet Mission Plan of 1946**
 2. The Commander-in-Chief of India while the Interim govt. was in operation. **Ans: General Sir Claude Auchinleck**
 3. The Muslim League finally joined the Interim Government on this date. **Ans: October 26, 1946**
 4. The members of the Constituent Assembly, from which the Interim Government was formed were chosen through this mechanism. **Ans: They were not elected directly by the public. Members were elected by the provincial legislative assemblies**
 5. The Interim Government ceased to exist on this date. Mention the major constitutional event which brought its tenure to an end. **Ans: It ceased to exist on August 15, 1947, when British India was partitioned and power was transferred to the new Dominions of India and Pakistan**
- Visual: Identify these members of the Interim Government. **Ans: (From left) Sarat Chandra Bose, Jagjivan Ram, Rajendra Prasad, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Asaf Ali, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru and Syed Ali Zaheer**
Early birds: Prem Nath Tiwari| Sitaram Saharay| Neil Lall| Anan E A Rahim| Venkat Parthasarathy

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Excoriate:

express strong disapproval of

Synonyms: condemn, reprobate, decry

Usage: *The activists excoriated the violence against minority communities.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/excoriate

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ɪkˈskɔː.i.ɛt/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Simple Energy forays into ‘family scooter’ segment

Bengaluru-based EV manufacturer Simple Energy on Wednesday unveiled Simple Wave, a new range of electric scooters aimed at family buyers. The range comprises three variants and is available in six colours – Pearl White, Coral Red, Twilight Black, Polar Blue, Dolphin Grey and Forest Green. The company claims the scooters offer an IDC range of up to 243 km and storage capacity of up to 70 litres. Prices start at ₹1,09,999 (ex-showroom).

Novonesis to invest ₹6,660 cr. in Maharashtra unit expansion

Danish biosolutions company Novonesis has announced an investment of ₹6,660 crore (€600 million) to expand its facility at Patalganga in Maharashtra and establish an advanced enzyme production facility. The expansion is aimed at increasing the company’s production capacity to meet growing global demand for biosolutions. The new facility, which is expected to be fully operational by 2030, will manufacture enzymes for a range of industries, including biofuels.

Essel chief opposes formation of 5-member NCLT bench

Essel Group Chairman Subhash Chandra on Wednesday opposed the formation of a five-member bench by the NCLT to decide his personal insolvency case, contending that the tribunal does not have the power to constitute such a bench. Appearing for Mr. Chandra before the appellate tribunal NCLAT, Senior Advocate Sasmit Patra termed the NCLT order “faulty and wrong” and said, “they are not empowered” to form a five-member bench. PTI

Textile mills under stress as cotton prices soar

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Textile mills are witnessing a revival in cotton-yarn demand with capacity utilisation crossing 90% but a sharp rise in cotton prices is raising concerns over operational sustainability. “Cotton yarn demand started reviving almost five months ago and now, mills are not holding much yarn stocks,” said Durai Palanisamy, chairman, Southern India Mills Association. Cotton prices had risen sharply since mid-March, with local prices moving in line with ICE Futures, he said, adding mills had relatively low inventories with most maintaining less than two months stock. Cotton prices which ranged between ₹51,700-₹57,000 a candy between October last and end March 2026 surged to ₹70,000/candy on September 2 on an ex-gin basis. “Factors such as higher demand from China and likely lower output from the U.S. and China are pushing up prices,” said Nishant Asher, secretary, Indian Cotton Federation. “Our cotton yarn cannot be used fully by local apparel sector. Textile mills need global opportunities for viable operations. Yarn prices adjust to cotton prices. Globally, too, yarn availability is under pressure, boosting prices,” said Ravi Sam, vice-chairman, Cotton Textile Export Promotion Council. Sources said Indian cotton prices were lower than global prices. The Cotton Corporation of India, which procured huge quantities of cotton at minimum support price, must stabilise prices.

Consultations on for offshore wind tenders in TN: official

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Consultations are on for introducing a new tender for wind offshore technology in Tamil Nadu, Rajesh Kulkari, Joint Secretary, Union Renewable Ministry told reporters here. Mr. Kulkari said feasibility studies conducted in the State had yielded positive results. “All [feasibility] studies have been completed in Tamil Nadu. The good news is capacity utilisation factor is more than 50%,” he stated, adding, “collection of required data for offshore wind off the coast of Tamil Nadu, that is, wind velocity, geo-technical and geo-physical – have been completed by the National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE).”



An offshore wind farm (for representative purpose only).

Thus, “In the near future, we will be trying to [bring] bid for that part of the country.” As part of its goal for leasing offshore wind energy sites, the government initially identified eight potential zones each off the coasts of Tamil Nadu and Gujarat in initial studies. It faced a setback in Tamil Nadu as tenders did not receive anticipated response.

VinFast said to put brakes on making some cars in India

Reuters
NEW DELHI

VinFast suspended plans to make three electric vehicles in India and ordered suppliers to halt work on the projects while it reviews costs, as per sources and a memo reviewed by Reuters – a year after Vietnam’s automaker entered the crucial growth market. VinFast asked suppliers to “hold all activities” on three programmes, including a two-door SUV called VF 3 – expected to be its most competitive model in the market – and VF 6 and VF 7 SUVs, which it imports from Vietnam and assembles in the country. The suspension marks another setback for loss-making VinFast which turned to India after difficulties in gaining market shares in U.S. and Europe.

Commerce Secretary to lead delegation to China ahead of Xi’s New Delhi visit

Amiti Sen
NEW DELHI

India is likely to send a high-level delegation to China early next week, possibly led by Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal, to advance talks on pending trade and investment issues. Ahead of President Xi Jinping’s expected visit to New Delhi for the BRICS Summit later this month, the talks would include widening trade imbalance and restrictions on Chinese investments, sources said. “Both India and China are keen to deepen bilateral trade and investment ties amid growing geopolitical uncertainties and the U.S. tariff onslaught. The proposed meeting between Chinese President Xi Jinping and Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi is likely to give fresh impetus to economic engage-



Rajesh Agrawal

ment between the two countries. The likely visit of the Indian delegation to China on September 7-8 could help firm up the agenda,” an industry source told *businessline*. The proposed visit has not been confirmed by the Commerce Department. However, three industry sources said inputs had been sought from exporters on tariff and non-tariff barriers in China ahead of the high-level delegation’s meetings. “Exporters were asked to highlight any difficulties

faced in accessing the Chinese market, including non-tariff barriers, regulatory requirements, customs procedures, product-specific restrictions and other impediments to exports,” the sources said. New Delhi is likely to flag concerns over its widening trade deficit with China, the need for greater market access, disruptions caused by sudden restrictions on critical inputs and technology, tariff and non-tariff barriers, and rejection of business visas, the source said. Beijing, meanwhile, is expected to seek further easing of restrictions on Chinese investments in India, including faster approvals and greater scope for investment in non-strategic sectors. Bilateral merchandise trade between India and China rose to around \$151.1 billion in FY26, with India’s exports climbing 36.7% to

\$19.47 billion. However, imports from China grew 16% to \$131.63 billion, widening India’s trade deficit to a record \$112.16 billion from \$99.2 billion in FY25. New Delhi is particularly concerned about its dependence on China for machinery, electronics and electronic components, lithium-ion batteries, fertilizers and other intermediate and capital goods. The proposed delegation’s visit comes amid a gradual thaw in bilateral ties, which had nosedived after the Galwan Valley clashes in 2020. This follows efforts by the two sides to stabilise relations and resolve outstanding border issues. Xi is expected to visit India for the BRICS Summit on September 12-13, which would be his first visit to the country in seven years. (The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Auto sector calls for deeper localisation to boost global manufacturing ambitions

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

India’s auto industry needs to move beyond local assembly and build domestic capabilities across the entire value chain – from raw materials and components to advanced technologies and final systems – to reduce supply-chain risks and strengthen global competitiveness, industry leaders said. Tata Motors MD Shailesh Chandra said India’s localisation push should go beyond import substitution and focus on establish-

Tata Motors MD said India’s localisation push should go beyond import substitution

ing the country as a major global automotive manufacturing and mobility hub. “The opportunity before is much larger than just import substitution,” he said, adding that India should aim to become “one of the world’s leading automotive manufacturing and mobility hubs.” He called for localisation to ex-

pand beyond conventional components to cover the full value chain, including raw materials, processing, components, sub-components and final systems. The recent disruption in rare-earth magnet supplies, he said, demonstrated how dependence on even a relatively small input could expose the industry to strategic supply-chain vulnerabilities. Maruti Suzuki India Managing Director and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said shifting global supply chains were creating an opportunity for India to emerge

as a trusted manufacturing and supply-chain base. “Cost is no longer the only consideration. Reliability and continuity have become equally important,” Mr. Takeuchi said. Hyundai Motor India Chief Operating Officer Tarun Garg said India’s trade profile highlighted the need for faster technological capability-building. “Our exports remain concentrated in relatively mature technologies, while our imports are increasingly dominated by advanced, higher-value technologies, Mr. Garg said.

Sanjana B
BENGALURU

Almost a quarter of PayPal’s about 6,700 India staff have either been laid off or are in the process of being laid off, sources said. A PayPal spokesperson said, “The recent staffing changes are part of previously announced multi-year transformation to simplify global operations, strengthen execution and position the firm for long-term growth. We are committed to supporting staff through this transition.” In May, media reports



The firm had earlier laid off 12% of staff in Ireland.

emerged the U.S.-based digital payments giant planned to cut about 20% global workforce over the next few years to hasten AI adoption and reduce costs. As per the firm’s annual

Canadian pension fund acquires 24% stake in Altius Telecom Infra

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Quebec-based La Caisse pension fund announced on Wednesday that it was acquiring a 24% stake in Altius Telecom Infrastructure Trust, India’s largest trust through which tower and other telecom infrastructure spending is directed. The acquisition entails a CA\$1.76 billion investment, or ₹12,100 crore. Canadian investment management MNC Brookfield remains the SEBI-registered Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT)’s largest shareholder.

‘Reflective of demand’ In a statement alongside Brookfield, La Caisse said that its acquisition “reflects growing demand for mobile connectivity and 5G infrastructure in India”.

The pension fund added, “India is the world’s second-largest telecommunications market, and continued growth in mobile data use and 5G is increasing the need for digital infrastructure.” While two of the three private telecom operators have spread their 5G networks throughout every district in India in record time, infrastructure spending is expected to grow as many sites are not directly connected through fiber optic cables, and more sites need to be added to expand coverage in semi-urban and rural areas to meet growing traffic demand by users.

How Japan’s bond rout is turning the tide of global capital



Yen for return: Holograms seen on the Japanese 1,000 yen banknote. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
TOKYO/LONDON

With benchmark Japanese bond yields breaking through a three-decade-old barrier, higher returns are starting to tease capital home, reversing what was once a dependable flow of funds into global bond markets.

The 3% threshold is significant not just for funding costs in Tokyo, but for turning around an investment flow that has made Japan the biggest owner of U.S. Treasuries and one of the most reliable buyers of sovereign debt worldwide.

As the global bond rout deepened on Wednesday, traders said part of the move rested on bets Japanese investors would retreat from overseas holdings.

While there’s no sign of Japan dumping its \$2.4 trillion hoard in overseas debt just yet, global fund managers and a growing body of data is showing a steadier drawdown is underway.

In Sydney, London and Singapore, bond dealers and asset managers have noticed the pullback of Japan’s demand. Official data shows Japanese investors have already sold a net ¥3 trillion (\$18.7 billion) in overseas debt through August 22, the biggest year-to-date outflow since bonds tanked in 2022.

“I know it first hand from talking to Japanese investors,” said Michael Weidner, co-head of global fixed income at Lazard Asset Management. “They’ve under invested in yen securities for probably 25 years. Now it’s become more attractive and they are reallocating.”

Toshinobu Chiba, a Tokyo-based fund manager at Simplex Asset Management, is one of those investors, saying he’s gone bearish on U.S. Treasuries and started buying the 10-year Japanese government bond just before its recent peak in yield.

‘Easier to buy’

“It’s easy to buy the 10-year at above 3%,” said Chiba. “Most of the lifers have a strong incentive to buy right now. It’s a natural movement for Japanese investors to pull money out of the U.S. and back into Japan.”

In Australia, a country in which Japanese investors were once the largest foreign holder of debt in pre-pandemic years, market participants are feeling a shift from buying to holding.

“This year (Japanese investors) have been less on accumulation and more holding their exposures reasonably consistent,” said Ryan Ellis, Citi’s head of markets sales for Australia and New Zealand.

“They’ve got a home market bias for the first time in a lot of years,” he said, and the Aussie market has been under pressure from central bank rate hikes. “It’s very much a return-driven decision,” he said.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
HONG KONG

While Nvidia is synonymous with the AI boom, a lesser-known group of power and cooling equipment suppliers is cashing in on a global data centre construction spree as developers race to avoid infrastructure bottlenecks.

Energy-hungry data centres have triggered a surge in demand for equipment ranging from transformers to advanced cooling systems, creating winners across Asia’s supply chain, though earlier stock-price gains have moderated.

McKinsey forecasts nearly \$7 trillion in data-

centre investment globally by 2030; Nvidia last week said it expects AI spending to remain robust for years.

Grid connection delays

But building data centres fast enough to meet demand is becoming more difficult. Hyperscalers often want facilities delivered within six months, but grid connection delays can stretch as long as 24 months in some emerging markets and more than eight years in major developed markets, according to consultancy Pivotal AI.

“Outside the industry circle, people are talking about (graphics processing units), but within the circle, people most certainly question you about the lead time for generators and transformers,” said

Trump pledged fiscal restraint; now debt tops \$40 tn as borrowing cost up

Debt surpasses \$40 trillion in first 19 months of Trump’s second term; Trump’s second-term tax and immigration law adds \$4.7 trillion in debt, CBO says; looming fiscal crisis will create headaches for future lawmakers, budget experts say; demographic shifts have also strained the budget

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Donald Trump returned to the White House promising to get the United States’ financial house in order by slashing the scope of the federal government, ending costly “forever wars” and spurring economic growth to tame spiralling deficits.

Instead, the national debt has surged past \$40 trillion in the first 19 months of his second term. Federal spending has grown, not shrunk. The six-month-old Iran war has become an expensive stalemate. And the cost of servicing the U.S. debt, meanwhile, has grown as yields on some U.S. bonds hit their highest levels in nearly two decades.

Looming fiscal crunch

The result, budget experts say, is a looming fiscal crunch likely to force Congress and a future president to take politically unpopular steps to either raise taxes or trim the social safety net, potentially including Social Security.

“There is no scenario in which one could look at the record of President Trump in both this term and the previous term, and declare it a fiscal success,” said Maya MacGuineas,



Damocles sword: Total U.S. National Debt surpassed \$40 trillion for the first time. REUTERS

president of the Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget, a centrist Washington think tank. “The way we got here was not his fault, but the fact that we are here and lawmakers have not done anything to improve it is all of their fault, with the president clearly being central and creating the agenda.”

The debt surpassed \$40 trillion just ahead of the upcoming November midterm elections that will determine if Republicans keep control of Congress for the second half of Trump’s final term. While voters may not focus on the issue until the country’s fiscal problems translate into benefit cuts or tax hikes, the fallout hits them just the same in the form of high mortgage in-

terest rates that track yields on government debt and inflation outpacing wage hikes.

Mounting debt

Trump has driven up spending across his two terms. His first-term tax cuts added \$8.4 trillion in debt, according to the Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget. His second-term tax and immi-

gration law added another \$4.7 trillion, according to the Congressional Budget Office, lawmakers’ non partisan bookkeeper.

White House spokesman Kush Desai said Trump was the “first president to seriously take on pervasive waste, fraud, and abuse across the federal government,” and cut spending by firing thousands of federal workers and eliminating “wasteful programmes.”

Trump and Congressional Republicans did shrink the annual deficit in 2025, but by a marginal amount, even as the overall debt continued to grow.

Deficit expansion

Both parties share responsibility. Tax cuts under Republican presidents Ro-

From street names to supply chains, Canadians are pulling away from America on growing rift

Reuters
OTTAWA



Weakening links: Ambassador Bridge, connecting Windsor, Ontario and Detroit, Michigan, in Windsor, Ontario, Canada. REUTERS

For more than 20 years, Diane Hosker has lived on Trump Avenue in Ottawa’s leafy west end, a neighborhood with New York City-themed street names including Central Park, Bloomingdale Street and Gotham Private.

Hosker was never a fan of the name, which was chosen when U.S. President Donald Trump was known primarily as a Manhattan real estate developer. Now, amid the worsening trade war and escalating verbal threats, the city council is moving to rename it.

Trump’s latest actions—imposing new tariffs on

goods from Canada and signing an executive order renaming Lake Ontario as “Lake America,” — have triggered a renewed surge of anger and patriotism in a country better known for being easygoing.

Some Canadians have boycotted U.S. products and stopped traveling south of the border since Trump returned to office in early 2025, but his renewed attacks on Canada are prompting what may

be a more permanent rupture between two longtime allies. From street names to supply chains to vacation bookings, Canadians are severing everyday ties in ways that could outlast the current trade dispute.

‘King of chaos’

“(Trump) is just the king of chaos and destroying everything and nothing good ever comes out of this man,” Hosker told Reuters. “I just don’t like the way he makes fun of Canada,” she said, adding that she finds it embarrassing to tell people she lives on a street named after Trump.

Ottawa City Councillor Riley Brockington said he’s taking steps to rename Trump Avenue. Some

ideas include TACO, a reference to “Trump Always Chickens Out,” or naming the street after former U.S. President Barack Obama.

“Street names in Canada’s capital are named after people of honour and integrity and (who) work in partnership, in this case, with Canada,” Brockington said. “(Trump) does not meet any of those standards.”

An Abacus Data poll released last week found that more than 70% of Canadians support Prime Minister Mark Carney’s decision to suspend trade talks with the U.S., despite the likelihood of job losses and economic uncertainty. Meanwhile, a Reuters/Ipsos poll showed only 20% of Amer-

icans support the tariffs on Canadian goods and even fewer agree with renaming the lake.

Some dual citizens are deepening their ties to Canada. Sara Seager, a Canadian-American astrophysicist who left MIT, is moving to Toronto after being recruited by the University of Toronto under the Carney government’s push to attract top academics from abroad.

“I explained how Prime Minister Carney is giving over a billion dollars to recruit top talent from all over, but especially Canadians, to come home to help Canada become more sovereign from the U.S. in technology, trade and defense,” she said.

Power, cooling firms riding trillion-dollar data centre boom



Power of cooling: A worker walks past a data centre in Johor state at Gelang Patah, Malaysia. REUTERS

Wing Kin Cheung, the CEO of digital infrastructure service provider BodaData. Transformers convert high-voltage electricity from grids into levels suitable for servers, cooling sys-

tems and power distribution units.

AI scrutiny deepens

Leading transformer suppliers including South Korea’s HD Hyundai Electric

and China’s Hainan Jinpan Smart Technology reported surging demand in the first half (H1) of 2026 tied to AI infrastructure projects, particularly in North America.

HD Hyundai Electric recently said demand in Europe was rising as U.S. hyperscalers expanded investments in markets like Finland, Germany and Britain, while Middle Eastern demand remained strong.

\$8.5 bn order backlog

HD Hyundai Electric’s order backlog rose 23% to \$8.5 billion at the end of June from six months earlier, and it expects data centre demand to remain robust.

“We currently have an order backlog covering more than three years, with a substantial portion of production capacity for major power equipment secured for the coming three years,” it told Reuters.

“We are also in order

discussions with some key customers for volumes scheduled for delivery as far out as 2030.”

For Jinpan, new data-centre orders in H1 more than quadrupled from a year earlier, while its related backlog nearly tripled. As AI chips consume more electricity, equipment makers are also betting on technologies aimed at improving efficiency and reducing environmental impacts, amid growing public scrutiny over data centres’ use of water and electricity.

Bank of America estimates power consumption per AI rack could climb to more than 1.5 megawatts by the end of 2030, nearly 100 times that of a conventional rack, citing Nvidia’s roadmap.

One technology attracting greater attention is the solid-state transformer (SST), a device that replaces bulky magnetic coils and copper windings with semiconductors to transform and route electricity.

UBS estimates SSTs will increase power efficiency by around 4% and reduce costs.

While commercial adoption remains in its early stages, it expects their penetration to climb to 40% in 2030 and forecasts that Chinese companies will gain share.

HD Hyundai Electric and Jinpan said they are deepening SST development, while Taiwan’s Delta Electronics, a major supplier of power infrastructure, said a small data centre is using its SSTs.



AI use will only be allowed in high school, which begins in the ninth grade, said a source. GETTY IMAGES

New York City to ban AI in schools through 8th grade

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

New York City will ban the use of artificial intelligence for students in public schools through eighth grade, a source close to the matter told AFP on Wednesday, confirming U.S. media reports.

Teachers and parents have warned against the use of AI in schools over concerns about harming children's mental health and cognitive development, as well as environmental damage.

AI use will only be allowed in high school, which begins in the ninth grade in the American school system, the source said. Even then, it will be limited to specific uses, such as learning about the technology itself, they said.

Eighth graders in the U.S. are typically about 13 years old.

New York City Hall and the city's education department did not immediately respond to AFP's request for comment. According to the New York Times, AI "companion chatbots" offering psychological support will also be banned.

The rules, however, allow teachers to use AI for tasks including preparing lessons or writing messages. The new rules are to be announced on Wednesday, the Times reported.

The city's education department recommends limiting screen time to 45 minutes in class for middle schoolers—sixth through eighth grade—and 30 minutes for elementary school students.

But the question remains of how to monitor AI use, since it often takes place outside the school environment.

The city's public school technology policies are closely watched by the rest of the United States, as it is by far the largest school district in the country, with over 900,000 students in 2024-2025.

Fearing a midterm rout, Trump aides push to keep Iran war 'quiet' for now

Poll reveals voters are unhappy about high gas prices as Republicans defend slim majorities in Senate and House of Representatives in the upcoming election; sources say Trump administration is focused on tightening economic pressure on Tehran for now; strikes may return after election, they say

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Top aides to U.S. President Donald Trump are pushing to keep the Iran war from escalating before November's midterm elections to contain Republican electoral losses, four people familiar with the discussions said, a strategy that is already under strain as the United States and Iran resume their back-and-forth attacks.

White House officials will consider ramping up military action after the November 3 vote, said the sources, who requested anonymity, though any return to full-scale conflict is far from a given.

For now, they said, the administration is focused on tightening the economic pressure on Iran in an effort to extract concessions in any future negotiation that months of military action failed to secure.

"We are keeping the pressure on Iran," one White House official said. "But November is a priority."

Keeping the war mostly contained until then would help prevent the unpopular conflict from dominating the news as Mr. Trump's Republicans campaign to defend thin majorities in the Senate and House of Representatives, said the sources, three of whom are White House officials.

Only 31% of Americans approve of the war, while some 63% disapprove, according to a late August Reuters/Ipsos poll, and voters are particularly unhappy about high gas prices.

A tactical pause could also give the U.S. military some breathing room to replenish its heavily depleted munitions stockpiles, the sources said.

Continuing strikes

But pulling off the play-it-cool strategy looks more difficult by the day. While the conflict remains much less intense than it was during the spring or during a flare-up in the middle of the summer, both sides have exchanged tit-for-tat strikes in recent days.

Iran's leaders, emboldened after months of disrupting traffic through the Strait of Hormuz and facing little internal unrest, will likely keep striking at U.S. and allied Gulf targets, including military bases, vessels and energy infrastructure, at least periodically, analysts said.

The U.S. will face pressure to retaliate, potentially leading to an escalatory spiral that would bring both sides back to a full-scale air war—whether or not the administration wants it.

Over the weekend, the U.S. struck rocket launchers on Iran's Larak Island after a month of relative calm, prompting Iran to



Politics at play: A billboard depicting U.S. President Donald Trump in a container on a building in Tehran, Iran, on Wednesday. REUTERS

fire missiles toward Jordan and the United Arab Emirates. On Tuesday, the U.S. hit more Iranian targets around the Strait of Hormuz.

"The regime has every incentive to disrupt the 'calm'—which is no real calm, after all, since the administration's explicit aim is to increase economic pressure massively on Iran," said Barbara Leaf, who served as the top State Department official for West Asia under former President Joe Biden.

Another wild card is Mr. Trump himself.

The President's approval rating has fallen from 40% to 33% since the conflict began, according to Reuters/Ipsos polling. Sources said he is not currently interested in escalation, but he is famously

prone to changing his mind and could change course in response to events.

On Tuesday, he threatened to escalate the conflict if Iran hits back against the latest U.S. strikes.

He has publicly said the upcoming elections were not factoring into this Iran strategy.

Depleted munitions

But as the war enters its seventh month, his White House finds itself increasingly constrained by logistical and political realities.

"The timetable has changed," one senior White House official said. Another added that the "calendar is driving Iran."

Reuters reported in August that the military had used "virtually all" of its supply of certain precision

missiles. On Sunday, the Washington Post reported that the heads of the Army, Navy and Air Force warned Pentagon chief Pete Hegseth in a written assessment that prolonging the war was unsustainable and would diminish the military's readiness in other theaters.

The Pentagon has said the military had "everything it needs to execute" its mission.

"President Trump has destroyed Iran's military capabilities and is crippling what's left of its abysmal economy with the most powerful naval blockade in world history and crushing sanctions," White House spokeswoman Olivia Wales said. "The President will continue to advance America's interests at home and abroad and

will never allow Iran to have a nuclear weapon."

America's Gulf allies—some of whom had pushed for aggressive action against Iran earlier in the war to weaken their main regional adversary—roundly urged the White House to de-escalate after a recent round of attacks in late July, regional diplomats said.

Currently, two White House officials said, Vice President J.D. Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio are among the high-ranking Trump aides who are on board with the idea of trying to keep the Iran conflict relatively "quiet" until November.

In recent weeks, administration officials have instead intensified an economic isolation campaign, during which the U.S. has threatened to slap countries that trade with Iran with massive sanctions, while maintaining its own blockade on the Strait of Hormuz.

The trade-focused strategy, however, has its own limits, analysts and officials said. Iran has spent decades under layers of U.S. and international sanctions that have battered its economy but have not deterred its leadership.

Additionally, some major world powers, like China, have not joined Washington's bid to isolate Iran, prompting questions about the campaign's effectiveness.

U.S. Energy Secretary in Caracas for deal on one-fifth of Venezuela's oil

Agence France-Presse
CARACAS

U.S. Energy Secretary Chris Wright arrived in Venezuela on Tuesday to finalise an oil deal granting the United States control of about one-fifth of the country's reserves.

U.S. President Donald Trump had announced the deal—which would give the U.S. majority control of 65 billion barrels of proven petroleum reserves—last week.

"Several deals" will be announced on Wednesday, Mr. Wright told reporters upon his arrival. "These investment deals in Venezuela are to bring peace, opportunity and prosperity to the people of Venezuela



An oil pumpjack operates on Lake Maracaibo in Cabimas, Venezuela, on Wednesday. AP

and to the people of the United States," he said.

Oil giant Chevron is also expected to announce a major expansion in Venezuela on the same day.

U.S. officials defended the deal, saying it would

lower oil prices for Americans and counter Russian and Chinese influence on Washington's doorstep.

U.S. grip on Venezuela

But there have been major questions about the agree-

ment, which comes as Washington maintains an unprecedented grip on the government in Caracas after toppling President Nicolas Maduro in January.

In a Spanish-language interview posted to YouTube on Tuesday, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said a private company is working with the U.S. to "normalize the Venezuelan economy."

In Caracas, some opposition lawmakers abstained from the show-of-hands vote to approve the U.S. deal, arguing they should first be able to view the written terms. "We need and are obliged to know what is written in the fine print," lawmaker Luis Emilio Rondon said.

Raging flames



Waging a fight: Fire personnel attempt to extinguish a wildfire in Ogan Ilir regency, South Sumatra, Indonesia, on Wednesday. REUTERS

Once symbols of war on IS, Kurdish women fighters seek role in new Syria

Reuters
QAMISHLI

Female Kurdish fighters who became global symbols of the fight against Islamic State are negotiating with Syria's new authorities to retain a combat role after a government overhaul left their future uncertain.

The Women's Protection Units, known as the YPJ, fought alongside the U.S.-backed Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) during Syria's civil war, helping drive Islamic State (IS) from large parts of the country's north and east.

The group became one of the conflict's most recognisable fighting forces, drawing international attention for its all-female ranks in battles against Islamic State militants.

Yet the future of the force has been thrown into uncertainty since the downfall of former president Bashar al-Assad in late 2024 and the emergence of a new government led by Islamist rebels.

The new authorities have sought to fold formerly autonomous armed groups into state institutions.

Last week, the SDF was formally dissolved, with its commander Mazloum Abdi appointed as an adviser to President Ahmed al-Sharaa and other SDF members joining the Defence Ministry.

But there are no women in Syria's new Defence Ministry, and the YPJ's commander Nowruz Ahmed said she was told in meetings with Mr. Sharaa last week in Damascus that her

fighters had no place in the military.

"We were aiming to join the army, because our forces have experience and expertise that would enable them to protect themselves in an organised way in the form of an independent brigade or battalion," she told Reuters at a military base in the northeastern Syrian city of Qamishli.

"Our main condition was that this force must be organised, must not be deployed to any place, and must not be in small groups. They rejected this proposal."

Role in limbo

The YPJ is now in talks with Syria's Interior Ministry as it seeks an alternative route to maintain an organised fighting force.



Organised forces: Women's Protection Units (YPJ) fighters gather in Hasakah, Syria, on August 22. REUTERS

The discussions come as the new administration reshapes Syria's security institutions following the end of a war that lasted more than a decade.

The Interior Ministry already includes female personnel through a tourism police force. Earlier this

year, Syria's central authorities proposed that YPJ fighters join that unit, according to sources briefed on the deliberations.

The proposal was rejected by the YPJ, the sources said. A YPJ spokesperson denied such an offer was ever made.

Ms. Ahmed told Reuters the YPJ had instead proposed joining the Interior Ministry's special operations forces, which more closely mirror her units' capabilities and could help increase female representation in otherwise male-dominated forces.

"When we discussed with the Interior Ministry, we told them that our forces comprise more than 1,500 fighters and we asked whether all these forces would be merged or not," she said. Ms. Ahmed expects a response "in the coming days."

Syria's Defence and Interior Ministries did not immediately respond to Reuters questions about the discussions.

In a statement to Kurdish outlet Rudaw on Friday, Interior Ministry spo-

kesperson Nouredine al-Baba said YPJ fighters would be welcomed into the Ministry's ranks, but gave no details on their potential role. Mr. Baba said units would be deployed all over Syria, and not be limited to one geographic zone.

Distrust persists

The talks are taking place against a backdrop of lingering Kurdish mistrust toward Syria's new rulers.

Many Kurds remain wary of Syria's new authorities, citing mass violence perpetrated by government-linked forces against minorities in 2025 and Mr. Sharaa's former role as the head of AlQaeda's Syria branch before he broke ties with the militant group.

The question of the

YPJ's future has broader significance for many Kurdish women, who view the force as a symbol of hard-won political and social gains achieved during the conflict.

"They always see women as weak. We as women don't draw our strength from men, nor do we draw our strength from the current state," said 20-year-old YPJ fighter Goksu Ciyager.

"Of course, we want to have a special case and we insist on this."

Penaber Baran, a 31-year-old YPJ unit commander, said Syria's constitution should explicitly guarantee a role for the force.

"Until today, we have never waited for anyone to defend us," she said. "We as women defended ourselves."

EALA MANIA
‘We’re very loud when it comes to supporting our people’



▲ Alex Eala's fans arrived in huge numbers when she trained and then played in her first round US Open match. One of them was Andrea Belen, who FaceTimed with her father during the session so he could see Eala. "Everyone went crazy. We're very loud when it comes to supporting our people," said Belen.

DOUBLY SWEET
To play on the day of my 40th birthday was special: Monfils



▲ Gael Monfils stood in the middle of the court and bowed to the crowd that treated the Frenchman to a roaring ovation on his 40th birthday. "To play on the day of my 40th birthday was special. You guys made it incredible," said Monfils to the fans at the Louis Armstrong Stadium, who sang happy birthday to him.

SHOWTIME
Frodin, Serena's body double in King Richard, hogs the limelight



▲ Thea Frodin once had to hit like Serena Williams in the *King Richard* movie in 2021. On Tuesday at the US Open, the 17-year-old showed some pretty good power of her own in real life. "Being aggressive has always been my game. Hopefully, the next time I meet her [Rybakina], I will see what I can do," said Frodin.

IN THE HOTSEAT
Red Bull's Lawson to race in Italian GP as injury keeps Hadjar out



▲ Liam Lawson will remain Max Verstappen's teammate at Red Bull for the Italian GP after Isack Hadjar failed to recover in time from his wrist injury, the team confirmed. Hadjar had said he was hopeful of returning for Sunday's race but will now miss a second event. Yuki Tsunoda gets a second race with Racing Bulls in Lawson's seat.

Zverev battles back from the brink to subdue Sonego

The top-seeded German was two points from defeat in the fourth set; French Open runner-up Cobolli also wins five-set marathon; Rybakina and Gauff move up with ease on rain-affected day

US OPEN
Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Top-seeded Alexander Zverev survived a scare, overcoming Lorenzo Sonego in a wild-five setter at the US Open on Tuesday as Elena Rybakina and Coco Gauff advanced with ease.

Zverev fought off a determined challenge from Italy's lowly ranked Sonego, winning 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(7), 7-5, 6-4 in a tense all-court battle spiced by unlikely retrievals, impossibly angled winners and some inexplicable errors, which wrapped up on Arthur Ashe Stadium after four hours and 53 minutes at 1:55 in the morning.

"I'm just happy I won, that's it. Incredible battle," said Zverev, who was two points from defeat trailing 5-4 in the fourth set.

The German held serve and broke Sonego in the next game, then earned the lone break of the fifth set to complete the win.

Fifth-seeded Flavio Cobolli, runner-up to Zverev at Roland Garros, rallied from two sets down for the first time in his career to beat Argentina's Francisco Comesana 3-6, 2-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4.

Nerves didn't seem to be a problem for ninth-seeded Taylor Fritz as he sailed past fellow American Darwin Blanch 6-3, 6-2, 6-4.

There was no such drama for women's World No. 2 Rybakina and former champion Gauff. Rybakina, eyeing a third Grand Slam title and the top ranking, beat US teen Thea Frodin



Finding his range: Zverev conjured up unlikely retrievals and hit impossibly angled winners. REUTERS

IMPORTANT RESULTS

Men: Second round: 7-Medvedev bt Gorznyi (USA) 6-1, 6-3, 7-5; Michelsen (USA) bt 16-Nakashima (USA) 6-3, 6-4, 6-4. **First round:** 1-Zverev (Ger) bt Sonego (Ita) 6-4, 3-6, 6-7(7), 7-5, 6-4; 13-Musetti (Ita) bt Fery (GBR) 6-3, 6-3, 7-5; 9-Fritz (USA) bt Blanch (USA) 6-3, 6-2, 6-4; 24-Cerundolo (Arg) bt Misolic (Aut) 6-4, 6-3, 7-5; 5-Cobolli (Ita) bt Comesana (Arg) 3-6, 2-6, 6-3, 6-4, 6-4. **Women: Second round:** 19-Paolini (Ita) bt Stefanini (Ita) 6-4, 6-1; 31-Fernandez (Can) bt Sawangkaew (Tha) 6-4, 6-1; 15-Shnaider bt Pliskova (Cze) 6-1, 6-3, 6-2.

Gauff showed off her immensely improved serve in a confident 6-3, 6-4 victory over 53rd-ranked Zeynep Sonmez of Turkey. Gauff blazed through the opening set before Sonmez upped her game, recovering an early break in the second and briefly tak-

ing the lead before Gauff regrouped. Kazakhstan's Rybakina showed little sign of the left heel injury that forced her out of her quarterfinal in Cincinnati this month. She saved both break points she faced in a polished performance against the big-hitting if erratic American, who was playing her first Grand Slam main draw match on a wild card.

Women's French Open champion Mirra Andreeva also advanced easily, cruising past Indonesia's 36th-ranked Janice Tjen 6-2, 6-2. Keys, a former Australian Open winner who lost in the first round at Flushing Meadows last year, conquered first-match jitters to beat 19-year-old Russian Alina Korneeva 7-5, 6-4.

While play went as scheduled on the covered Ashe and Armstrong stadiums, those on outside courts – including Rybakina – had to wait out some lengthy rain delays.

That included a near four-hour delay to the start of play and more delays in the evening. Five late matches were postponed altogether and a handful of others suspended.

For the current generation of cricket fans, Tilak Varma's image is that of a dashing, short-format batter for India and Mumbai Indians. But over the last four days in the Duleep Trophy, the 23-year-old revealed another face – that of a steely red-ball player.

Captaining South Zone in the semifinal versus North, he made an unbeaten 116 from 250 balls to rescue his side from a precarious 80 for five. In the second essay, he was unconquered on 51 (79b) as South chased 181 with ease.

"I have always loved red-ball cricket," Tilak said after his match-winning performance.

"I had never dreamt of playing white-ball [cricket] for India, but it's God's plan that I have played T20 and One-day for India. But my strength is the red-ball game."

Numbers back this assertion. Though he has featured in just two First Class matches in the last 11 months, the Hyderabad southpaw has scored 1,729

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

An omnipresent Tilak Varma fashioned South Zone's entry into the 2026-27 Duleep Trophy final with a thumping seven-wicket triumph over North Zone at the BCCI Centre of Excellence here. The 23-year-old from Hyderabad, who had starred in the first innings with an ultra-patient, unbeaten 116 (250b), scored a breezy half-century (51 n.o., 79b, 8x4) on Wednesday to help South chase 181 and set up a final date with East Zone in Chennai starting this Sunday.

Tilak first batted during a nervous few minutes towards the end of day one. He then occupied the crease for the whole of day two, helped swell South's first-innings lead to 117 on day three before coming up with a first-rate finishing act on the final day.

And when he was not batting, he was marshalling his team's resources as cap-



The orchestrators: After Nidheesh restricted North's lead, South skipper Tilak, left, took over. K. MURALI KUMAR

tain, making it an all-encompassing show.

North began the final morning from 256 for seven, ahead by 139 runs. But Kerala pacer M.D. Nidheesh cleaned up the tail to

claim his 10th First Class five-wicket haul (five for 56) and limit North's lead to under 200.

A 64-run, opening-wicket partnership between Ricky Bhui (42, 53b, 7x4)

and N. Jagadeesan (43, 83b, 4x4) set South on course before Tilak and R. Smaran (32 n.o., 42b, 4x4, 1x6) combined for an unbroken 80-run stand.

Tilak drove beautifully, almost always getting to the pitch of the ball and caressing the red cherry. His batting range could be seen in the back-to-back fours off left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq, one reverse-swept and the other padded. North was tardy on the field. There were misfields galore, and as many as 12 byes, with Kanhaiya Wadhawan and Abdul Samad alternating wicket-keeping duties. The spiciest moment came when pacer Gurnoor Brar was livid with Wadhwan for dropping Jagadeesan on 14. It would have helped if Brar's aggression had percolated through the side, but it never did.

The scores: North Zone 195 & 297 in 72.4 overs (Sanat Sangwan 76, Ayush Doseja 52, M.D. Nidheesh 5/56) lost to South Zone 312 & 182/3 in 43.1 overs (Ricky Bhui 42, N. Jagadeesan 43, Tilak Varma 51 n.o.).

Tilak says he wants to play in the final

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

South Zone skipper Tilak Varma expressed hope that he would be able to play the Duleep Trophy final against East Zone in Chennai starting this Sunday despite the short turnaround time between the marquee contest and the first T20I versus Afghanistan.

Tilak, who is India's T20 vice-captain, will have to finish the final on September 10 and travel to Delhi for the international game scheduled for the 13th. East skipper Ishan Kishan and his deputy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi are also in the same boat.

"I want to play in the final," Tilak told reporters on Wednesday after the triumph over North Zone. "We have two days break in between. But it depends

on the selectors and the management."

Tilak hoped that speedster Vidwath Kaverappa, who didn't take the field starting from the post-tea session on day three (Tuesday), will be available.

"His [left] ankle is slightly swollen, but he can walk and he is also running with a tape. I feel he will be there in the final. But let's see."

Karnataka stalwart Karun Nair, who scored 699 runs in the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy, was benched for the semifinal to accommodate Hyderabad's K. Himateja. Tilak said it was purely because of team combination.

"North had two left-arm spinners, and we wanted a lefty in the middle-order. Himateja is a youngster (24) and has scored decent runs (485). It was very unfortunate for Karun."

Mumbai, Vadodara to host first women's CT

Agencies
DUBAI

The International Cricket Council (ICC) announced on Wednesday that the inaugural women's Champions Trophy 2027 will be held in Mumbai and Vadodara from Feb. 14 to 28.

Top six outfits Mumbai's Cricket Club of India (CCI) and the Vadodara International Cricket Stadium will be the venues for the tournament which will bring together six of

the world's top sides – Australia, England, India, New Zealand, South Africa and Sri Lanka. The teams, which qualified as per their ICC T20I rankings on the July 6 qualification cut-off date, will play in a round-robin league. The top two will progress to the final on February 28.

"With a marquee ICC women's event now taking place every year, we have an opportunity to build greater momentum for the women's game," said Jay Shah, ICC chairman.

Stakeholders to meet today to chart India's roadmap till ODI World Cup

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) will convene a critical stock-taking meeting of key stakeholders of India's men's cricket teams at its headquarters here on Thursday.

It is understood that the meeting will seek to take a deep dive into the issues that have affected India's performances of late and chart a roadmap through to next year's ODI World Cup, including a possible extension of chief selector Ajit Agarkar's tenure.

Multiple sources in the BCCI have confirmed that head coach Gautam Gambhir, Agarkar, Centre of Excellence head of cricket V.V.S. Laxman, captains Shubman Gill and Shreyas



Agarkar's extension as chief selector will be discussed. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUEL YOGINI

Iyer, and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia will attend the meeting in person. Two key BCCI executives are also expected to be present, while some other office-bearers may join via videoconference.

Having taken charge in July 2023, Agarkar's current contract expires at the

end of this month. With BCCI regulations capping a selector's tenure at four years, he is eligible to continue until next September.

That would ensure continuity through the ODI World Cup, scheduled to begin in October 2027. However, India's poor returns in ODIs and the cold war between Agarkar and the BCCI hierarchy over Rohit Sharma's future in international cricket are likely to feature in the deliberations.

The injury-management mechanism at the CoE is another area that has come under criticism from the selection committee and team management. As a result, despite the recent PR overdrive around the CoE, BCCI office-bearers are keen to proactively come

up with a plan for a more effective injury-management system.

Scheduling overlaps between key India-A and international assignments and major domestic fixtures are also expected to be discussed. India-A's shadow tour of New Zealand coinciding with the ODI series against the Kiwis has left little room for adequate Test preparation ahead of the crucial series in November.

The poor run of the limited-overs teams in Ireland and England will also come under detailed scrutiny. Saikia had announced a review meeting immediately after the England tour concluded in mid-July, but it could not be convened because of the unavailability of key personnel.

INBRIEF



‘Humiliated’ Aubameyang quits Gabon national team

Gabon captain Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang has announced that he is stepping back from the national team, saying he felt “humiliated” by his exclusion and subsequent reinstatement after the 2025 Africa Cup of Nations in Morocco. The top scorer in the history of the Panthers was singled out by the Gabonese government as responsible for the AFCON failure. “They humiliated and smeared me even though I played at the AFCON while injured,” the 37-year-old said.

Anahat and Ramit advance in London Squash Classic

Reigning World junior champion Anahat Singh eased past Egypt’s Mariam Metwally 11-3, 11-2 to enter the second round of the \$144,000 London Squash Classic. In the men’s first round, Ramit Tandon defeated Qatar’s Abdullah Al-Tamimi 11-6, 11-7 but Veer Chotrani lost to Yannick Wilhelmi of Switzerland 9-11, 9-11.

Women in Blue keen to iron out batting flaws

The seven-time champion would look for a better performance ahead of its game against Pakistan on Saturday; Hong Kong’s Lamplough will be the bowler to watch out for in Thursday’s match

ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

India will need to sort out its batting frailties for a more complete performance when it faces Hong Kong in its second match of the Women’s T20 Asia Cup on Thursday.

The seven-time champion survived some anxious moments after a batting collapse in the second half of the first innings in its opening match against Thailand.

Leeway

India will have more leeway to iron out its issues ahead of bigger battles, including against Pakistan in its last Group A-game.

Shafali Verma shone brightly with a quick-fire 64, while Deepti Sharma too proved her mettle, taking



Practice makes perfect: Harmanpreet & Co. gear up for the Hong Kong game. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ing three wickets without conceding a run to emerge as the highest wicket-taker

in women’s T20Is. Smriti Mandhana and Pratika Rawal will hope to

Wadoo appointed as head coach of India’s under-17 men’s team

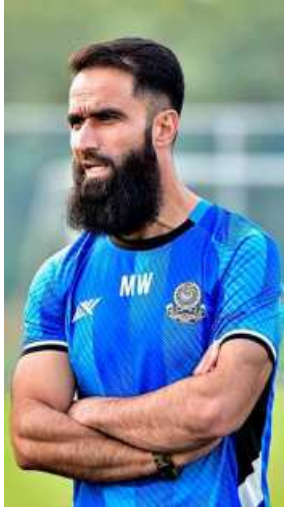
FOOTBALL

ANI
NEW DELHI

The AIFF has appointed former India international Mehrajuddin Wadoo as the head coach of the India u-17 men’s national team. Wadoo has taken charge of the team as the Blue Colts began their preparatory camp in Margao on Wednesday.

The camp is in its trial phase as preparations begin for the AFC u-17 Asian Cup Uzbekistan 2027 Qualifiers. India has been drawn in Group E of the Qualifiers, which will be held in Kuala Lumpur from November 11 to 20. The Blue Colts will face host Malaysia, Palestine, Singapore and Guam in the group.

An AFC Pro Licence holder, Wadoo brings considerable experience as both a player and coach. He most recently served as



Wadoo. FILE PHOTO

head coach of Mohammedan Sporting Club and has previously been head coach of Real Kashmir FC and Sudeva Delhi FC.

As a player, Wadoo represented the Indian national team and was part of the squad that won the AFC Challenge Cup in 2008, and went on to represent the country at the AFC Asian Cup in 2011.

Parkinson’s Law, Butterfly Effect and the beautiful chaos of deadline day

PL TRANSFERS

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

Every deadline day is an opportunity to remember Parkinson’s Law.

C. Northcote Parkinson’s 1955 satirical observation that work expands to fill the time available for its completion was validated once again as English clubs squeezed every last second of the clock before the Premier League summer transfer window closed at 3.30 a.m. IST on Wednesday.

The biggest (read costliest) deadline-day move came as Argentina midfielder Enzo Fernandez swapped Chelsea’s royal blue for Manchester City’s lighter shade.

The £125 million deal came after the London outfit had reportedly set an August 14 deadline for the player it valued at £120 million. In the end, Man City got its man, and Chelsea pocketed a tidy profit on a player it bought for £107 million in 2023.

Chain reaction

Waiting until the very last moment is risky business, especially when the whole ecosystem relies on a delicate



News and newsmakers: While Fernandez swapped Chelsea’s royal blue for Manchester City’s lighter shade, Fofana was at the centre of one of the most dramatic transfers. X@MNCITY & INSTAGRAM@MALICK FOFANA

cate chain reaction.

A player’s transfer from one badge to another doesn’t just affect the two clubs involved. The ripple effect of that one signature may disrupt or open avenues for other teams and players in the ecosystem, setting off or cancelling a slew of incomings and outgoings by virtue of the original transfer.

In other words, Ray Bradbury’s Butterfly Effect, too, assumes utmost

significance in the world of football.

Ask Chelsea, and it will tell you how it came close to signing Monaco’s Lamine Camara as Fernandez’s replacement, only for the French club to renege on the deal because of striker Folarin Balogun’s proposed departure to Everton bringing in enough cash to the club. In a late twist, Balogun chose not to move to Merseyside, a decision that left all three



of Chelsea, Monaco and Everton unhappy and blindsided!

Lyon’s Malick Fofana was at the centre of one of the most dramatic deadline day transfers. After Arsenal reportedly decided not to spend big on the Belgian winger, Sunderland and Crystal Palace entered the fray. According to reports, Fofana had two private jets waiting for him at Lyon airport, one set for Sunderland, and the other

for London. While Palace initially thought it had successfully hijacked Sunderland’s agreement with Fofana, the player ultimately decided to ply his trade at the Stadium of Light.

The 2026-27 Premier League deadline day had it all: a record-shattering transfer, two private jets on a runway, and a collapsed multi-club domino chain.

After all, what is deadline day without some chaos and manic buying?

Atiqa records two top-four finishes in WSK Final Cup

MOTORSPORTS

Press Trust of India
FRANCIACORTA (ITALY)

Indian racing prodigy Atiqa Mir overcame set-up issues to collect two impressive top-four finishes in the opening round of the WSK Final Cup here, continuing her upward trajectory in the world of karting.

The qualifying session didn’t go as per plan for the 11-year-old and she could only set the ninth fastest time.

However, the first Indian to be backed by the F1 Academy, made flying starts in both race one and two to charge through the field and secure creditable



Atiqa. X@FIA

back-to-back fourth place finishes. Following the two heat races, Atiqa was classified P14 among as many as 72 drivers.

This put her seventh on the grid for the pre-final where she eventually finished ninth after running fifth for the majority of the

race. In the final, Atiqa was involved in a crash that damaged her kart and ended her race.

“A mixed weekend for me. I was expecting more but we were struggling for pace.

“I managed to fight my way up in most of the races and was in a competitive spot for the pre finals and finals.

“But things didn’t go my way and the lack of pace hurt us on the long straights of Franciacorta,” said the JK Tyre and Raise-backed driver.

Atiqa will next be seen in the fourth round of the Champions of the Future Academy in Spain. She had dominated the Greece round earlier this year.

Lakshya bows out in the opener; Srikanth and Tanvi advance

BADMINTON

Press Trust of India
SHENZHEN

Lakshya Sen was knocked out of the China Masters after a listless performance in the opening round but K. Srikanth and Tanvi Sharma registered straight-game wins to progress to the second round of the men’s and women’s singles competition on Wednesday.

Lakshya played an error-riddled game to go down 14-21, 7-21 in 38 minutes to World No. 9 Canada’s Victor Lai, who won his second bronze medal at the World championships last month. It was Lakshya’s third defeat to the Canadian, with his only win coming at the All England Championships in March this year.

Srikanth, however, progressed after beating Taiwan’s Chi Yu Jen 21-16, 21-15 in another men’s singles opener.

The former World No. 1 will face Lai next. Tanvi, who won her maiden BWF World Tour title at the Taipei Open last month, defeated Denmark’s Amalie Schulz 21-16, 21-17 to advance to the women’s singles second round.

The 17-year-old will face Japan’s Tomoka Miyazaki next. However, Devika Sihag went down 18-21, 15-21 to Bulgaria’s Kaloyana Nalbantova to end her campaign. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty also moved to the next round with a 21-11, 21-16 win over Malaysia’s Junaidi Arif and Kang Khai Xing.

The Asian Games gold medalist pair will next take on the Popov brothers –

Christo and Toma Junior – of France.

India’s mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto too entered the next round after defeating Thailand’s Tonnakorn Saeheng and Tonnicha Saeheng 21-8, 21-9. The duo will meet Taiwan’s Liu Kuang Heng and Hsu Yin-Hui next.

The results: first round: Women: Tanvi Sharma bt Amalie Schulz (Den) 21-16, 21-17; Kaloyana Nalbantova (Bul) bt Devika Sihag 21-18, 21-15. **Men:** K. Srikanth bt Chi Yu Jen (Tpe) 21-16, 21-15; Victor Lai (Can) bt Lakshya Sen 21-14, 21-7. **Doubles: Men** Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty bt Junaidi Arif and Kang Khai Xing (Mas) 21-11, 21-16. **Mixed:** Dhruv Kapila & Tanisha Crasto bt Tonnakorn Saeheng and Tonnicha Saeheng (Tha) 21-8, 21-9; Wu Guan Xun and Lee Chia Hsin (Tpe) bt Rohan Kapoor & Ruthvika Gadde 21-16, 21-18.



Easy-peasy: Srikanth progressed after breezing past Taiwan’s Chi Yu Jen. FILE PHOTO: K.V.S. GURI

‘Cricketers to get best rooms at the Asian Games’

Agence France-Presse
TOKYO

Cricketers at this month’s Asian Games in Japan will have better accommodation than athletes from many other sports, the head of Japanese cricket said on Wednesday, after concerns were raised about a lack of five-star hotels for players.

A Sri Lankan official said this week that some of Asia’s top teams had raised doubts over facilities and accommodation at the Games, which are taking place in Nagoya and the wider Aichi area from September 19.

Cricket is a minor sport in Japan and games will be played at a new purpose-built ground with reports of tents serving as dressing rooms and distant wash-

room facilities.

There is no dedicated athletes’ village at the Games, with organisers instead relying on cabins in a cruise ship, rooms in temporary wooden containers and hotels.

Organisers said last week that accommodation was already stretched to the limit after the number of Asian Games athletes ballooned to 17,000.

By comparison there were around 11,000 at the 2024 Paris Olympics.

The cricket tournament is being run by the Asian Games organising committee in collaboration with the Asian Cricket Council (ACC).

Naoki Alex Miyaji, the CEO of the Japan Cricket Association, said that the two bodies had been discussing accommodation

options “for a long time”. “The participating teams in cricket are being offered hotel accommodation,” Miyaji said on Wednesday.

“Many other sports are being accommodated in much more limited facilities such as a cruise ship or container hotels.”

Matches will be played at Korogi Sports Park, a converted baseball field that is a 40-minute train ride away from central Nagoya.

LIVE TELECAST

T20 Women’s Asia Cup: India vs Hong Kong, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.

US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m. & 4.30 a.m. (Friday)

Laliga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Friday)

Padikkal moves up, Gill and Bumrah slip in Test rankings

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

Captain Shubman Gill slipped two positions among batters and Jasprit Bumrah dropped one spot down among bowlers, while Devdutt Padikkal rose up to the 54th spot among Indians in the latest ICC Test rankings released on Wednesday.

Gill slipped two positions to reach ninth as wicketkeeper-batter Rishabh Pant remains the highest ranked Indian batter in Test cricket at seventh.

There was no change in position for Yashasvi Jaiswal as the Indian opener is ranked outside the top 10 at 11th. Padikkal moved up five places up to reach the 54th position. Bumrah lost



Padikkal. PTI

his second spot in the rankings for Test bowlers and is now placed third behind Mitchell Starc and Matt Henry.

Bumrah had missed the tour of Sri Lanka owing to an impact injury on his knee which has sidelined him from action since mid-July.

From the Wall to the Hall

Once a boy who broke racquets and scrubbed toilets for it, Federer turned a hot temper into quiet grace and routine brilliance into religion, becoming tennis’ closest thing to a spiritual experience. In Newport on Sunday, the Hall of Fame simply made it scripture

Anirudh Velamuri

There should be a word for what Roger Federer did on a tennis court, because “played” barely covers it. Watching him felt like being granted a glimpse of the divine, and that’s no exaggeration. Your jaw went slack, your eyes bulged, and sounds escaped your body that no grown adult should make over a man hitting a felt ball with a string racquet.

Federer did not invent anything. Every shot in his arsenal had been struck before, by someone else in some other era.

Yet, in his hands, the borrowed became the sacred, the familiar became revelation, as if the shot had been waiting its whole life for him specifically to unlock it. And he didn’t do it once in some career-defining flash of magic. He did it for the better part of two decades. It was a residency in genius, not a hot streak. Pete Sampras once said Federer’s game had no weaknesses, and it stands true. What other players built entire careers on – a single jaw-dropping moment etched into a highlight reel – Federer treated as routine.

Except, of course, that routine came around roughly a thousand times, spread across four Grand Slams and every corner of the world, and it never once stopped feeling like the first time. That is the strange arithmetic of Federer’s greatness: repetition should have dulled the wonder, but it never did. Familiarity, in his case, only sharpened the awe.

Now the residency has its plaque. The felt ball has been put down, the sermons have ended, and what’s left is the reckoning every great career eventually meets – not a match, but a monument.

On Sunday, the world celebrated Federer once again as he was inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame. It is the sport’s great farewell and its eternal afterlife in the same breath, a place where a player’s brilliance is carved into permanence, even as it reminds them that greatness is never solitary.

The crowd said as much. Billie Jean King, Martina Navratilova, Stefan Edberg, John McEnroe, Andy Roddick and many others were on hand to celebrate one of tennis’ finest champions.

And closer still sat the ones who needed no introduction. His parents, Robert and Lynette. His wife, Mirka, and his four kids that the tennis world had watched grow up, one Slam at a time, in players’ boxes scattered across the globe—.

Mirka spoke first and introduced her husband with a line that outshone every statistic that followed. “What makes me proudest isn’t what Roger accomplished when the world was watching. It’s who he is when nobody’s watching,” she said.

He, too, glowingly praised the one person who has seen the highs and lows of his stardom from a touch away, while also building a semblance of a normal life together.

“Mirka inspires me every day. She showed me how to stay focused on tennis and take joy in everything else. A wonderful mother to our four kids... she makes the impossible happen. We grab each other’s hands, and we run through walls.”

More than trophies

For once, the man who made the impossible look routine was undone by his own history. He tried, and failed, to hold it together – pausing a few times to wipe his eyes, half-laughing through his tears. At one point, he pleaded for tissues and sunglasses, but pressed on anyway, the way he always had.

When he steadied himself enough, he spoke not of the trophies or numerous records. He was more focused on the more than 5,000 headbands he wore, the more than 7,000 pairs of socks he went through, some 10,000 racquets strung over the years, and the thousands of sets played on the same two knees.

“I tried to show my love for the game. Because it really mattered to me, and I also wanted it to matter to you. To be worthy of your attention, worthy of your attendance, because people don’t have to come watch us play. They come to be entertained, inspired, excited. They could always decide to go somewhere else, but they chose tennis, they chose us,” he emphasised.

The 45-year-old even wandered back to where it all began, not in any packed



stadium but in the shadows just off it.

“I remember being a ball boy in Basel, standing against the back wall, hands behind me, eyes on the ball. I’ll never forget how the game looked from there... the intensity, the adversity, the feeling of being so close to the players. I remember the next morning, my legs were gone... standing all day is a lot of work.”

Federer, especially later in his career, had the power to make the smallest cog in the wheel seen and appreciated. His core memory helped him do the same once more at Newport.

“I really want to thank every ball kid who ever stood through my matches or all our matches, for that matter, for hours on end. I see you. I thank you. I was you.”

It’s a strange, fitting symmetry: that is precisely how everyone felt watching his career unfold. Standing still, eyes fixed on the ball, absorbing the intensity as though they were pressed against the back wall of the court – even from several hundred or several thousand kilometres away, on the other side of the television screen.

More than a hundred titles in his cabinet, and yet Federer insisted the number was never the point.

“They call this the Hall of Fame... but fame was never the goal. My goal was to spend my life doing something I love, with people who love it as much as I do.”

And he did – relentlessly, joyfully, for the better part of his life. Federer didn’t just win; he took tennis to altitudes it hadn’t

reached before, wrote storylines the sport had never dared to script, and handed the world rivalries (with Rafael Nadal and Novak Djokovic) that will be studied and mythologised for generations.

Smashed racquet, softened man

There was a time when the future maestro was closer to a menace. As a boy in Basel, he didn’t play tennis so much as wage a war with it – swearing between points, smashing racquets and the whole kit and caboodle. At 16, he tore through a practice backdrop, understandably earning a week-long toilet-scrubbing sentence from his coach.

By his own admission, the unlearning took years and was no epiphany. The real turning point wasn’t a victory or defeat, but a tragedy – the death of his childhood coach Peter Carter in 2002, which recalibrated Federer for good.

Self-deprecation became an art form, just like most things would with Federer. The same man, on Sunday, would hold up two ageing knees to a crowd of legends and grin, saying, “Still got them, by the way. If I fall, please catch me.” The once hot-headed boy is now at ease with

laughing at himself, and became the most graceful man in tennis – on the court and off it. And he did it all with the same unhurried smile, even in the moments when the headband was fighting a losing battle against the sweat of another title run, even when his body was being pushed past what bodies are supposed to give.

“I’m still writing my love letter to tennis. My time as a player is done, but tennis will always stand at the intersection of everything I care most about... my family, our friendships, the past 40 years and the future we’re building. So this is not a goodbye,” he stated.

“We all leave the court eventually, but the sport keeps evolving. This boy from Basel thanks you... and I thank all of you for sharing the journey.”

It is the tennis world, though, that owes its thanks to Federer.

He carried the sport to spaces it had never been invited into before – into living rooms of people who couldn’t tell a forehand from a backhand, into the vocabulary of art critics and poets who had never once written about sport, into a kind of beauty that made the utilitarian business of winning feel almost secondary. He turned rivalry into reverence, opponents into co-authors, and a simple racquet into something closer to a paintbrush.

The ball boy became the main event. And the boy who once stood against the back wall, eyes fixed on the ball with hands behind his back, has finally taken his place among the very heroes he once watched from the shadows.

That, perhaps, is the only ending fitting enough: not a farewell, but a homecoming.

Career in numbers

1 The only male player to appear in seven consecutive Wimbledon finals (2003 to 2009)

8 Federer holds the record for most Wimbledon men’s singles titles

19 Grass was Federer’s most successful surface, where he won an Open Era record 19 titles (including a record 10 Halle Open titles)

20 Number of Grand Slam singles titles he won. He is the first man in history to reach the milestone

31 The number of Grand Slam finals reached (20-11 win-loss record)

56 His record win streak on hard courts (2005 ABN AMRO World Tennis Tournament in Rotterdam to the 2006 Dubai Duty Free Tennis Championships)

103 Number of career titles won

224 Career victories against top-10 opponents, with a 64.6 win percentage

237 Holds the record for most consecutive weeks as World No. 1 (February 2, 2004 to August 17, 2008)

310 Number of weeks spent as the top-ranked player in the world, second only to Djokovic (428)

1,526 The number of matches Federer played (won 1,251 and lost 275)

